

Catania

A Travel Guide for Your Family

14–20 MARCH 2026 · EASTERN SICILY

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Chapter 1: Welcome to Sicily

"Sicily is not Italy. It is something stranger, older, more layered — an island that has been conquered by everyone and domesticated by no one."

You are about to land on the largest island in the Mediterranean. As the plane descends and you get your first glimpse of the coastline — dark volcanic rock, turquoise water, the white sprawl of a city against a mountain that is quietly, constantly smoking — it's worth pausing to take it in. Whatever you were expecting, Sicily will be something slightly different.

That's not a warning. It's the best thing about it.

1.1 The Island in Numbers

Before the stories, a quick orientation.

Sicily sits at the toe of Italy's boot, separated from the mainland by the Strait of Messina — a gap of just 3 kilometres at its narrowest. It is the largest island in the Mediterranean, roughly the size of Switzerland, with a coastline of nearly 1,500 km. Five million people live here, and they will tell you, with varying degrees of seriousness, that they are Sicilian first and Italian second.

The island has five UNESCO World Heritage Sites. It has one active volcano — Europe's largest, and one of the most active in the world. It has Greek temples that predate the Parthenon. It has baroque towns rebuilt from scratch after one of the worst earthquakes in European history. It grows blood oranges, pistachios, capers, almonds, and some of the most interesting wine grapes on the continent.

It also has the best street food in Italy, and anyone who disagrees with that is wrong.

Sicily at a Glance



1.2 Who Made Sicily? The Five-Minute Version

Here is the thing about Sicily: it has been invaded, colonised, conquered, and ruled by almost every major power in Mediterranean history. The Greeks came. Then the Romans. Then the Arabs, the Normans, the French, the Spanish. Each one left something behind — in the food, the architecture, the language, the face of the person selling you a cannolo.

What makes Sicily extraordinary is not that all these cultures passed through, but that they layered. They didn't replace each other — they accumulated. You can see it in a single building in Palermo: Arab arches, Byzantine mosaics, Norman stonework, Spanish baroque facade, all on the same church. You can taste it in a single dish: aubergine, pine nuts, raisins, tomato, vinegar — ingredients and flavour combinations that trace a line directly back to the Arab kitchen of the 10th century.

Eating in Sicily, it turns out, is a form of time travel.

The cast of characters, in rough order of arrival:

The Greeks arrived around 750 BC and set up colonies along the east and south coasts. They built Syracuse into one of the most powerful cities in the ancient world — larger than Athens at its peak. They left behind theatres, temples, and a geometric approach to town planning that you can still read in the street grids of Catania and Syracuse. When you stand in the Greek theatre at Taormina and look out at the sea, you are standing where Aeschylus may have stood. That is not nothing.

The Romans arrived in the 3rd century BC, took Sicily after a long and nasty war with Carthage, and promptly turned the island into their grain basket. Sicily fed Rome. In exchange, the Romans built roads, cities, and some extraordinary mosaics — the Villa Romana del Casale near Piazza Armerina has floor mosaics so well preserved they look freshly laid. The Romans were efficient. They were not the most interesting rulers Sicily ever had.

The Arabs are the surprise. From the 9th to the 11th century, Arab and Berber forces from North Africa ruled much of Sicily, and what they left behind was transformative. They brought citrus trees: the orange and lemon groves that still cover the Conca d'Oro plain near Palermo. They brought sugar cane and the concept of iced sweets — the ancestor of every granita you will eat on this trip. They brought rice (arancino), aubergine, and a spice palette — cinnamon, saffron, cumin — that survives in Sicilian cooking to this day and makes it unlike any other regional Italian cuisine. They also improved the irrigation systems, reorganised agricultural production, and by most accounts governed the island rather well.

The Normans are the strangest chapter. Normans — descendants of Vikings who had settled in northern France, then carved out territories in southern Italy — conquered Sicily in the 11th century. What they built there is one of the genuine artistic miracles of the medieval world: churches that combined Arab geometric decoration, Byzantine gold mosaics, and Norman stone architecture into something that shouldn't work but absolutely does. The Cappella Palatina in Palermo is the finest example. It looks like nowhere else on Earth.

The Spanish arrived in the 15th century and stayed for two and a half centuries. Their most visible legacy is the baroque — that theatrical, extravagant, almost defiantly optimistic architectural style that defines the towns of eastern Sicily. After the catastrophic earthquake of 1693 levelled most of the east coast, Spanish-era aristocrats and the Church rebuilt on a grand scale. The result is the Val di Noto, a collection of baroque towns so remarkable they are a UNESCO World Heritage Site as a group. Catania is one of them.

Modern Italy arrived in 1861 with unification, which many Sicilians greeted with ambivalence then and regard with ambivalence now. Sicily remained, and remains, a place apart. The dialect is so different from standard Italian that some linguists classify it as a separate language. The culture, the food, the pace, the priorities — all distinctly Sicilian.

Fun fact to tell your toddler in about fifteen years: The word sugar comes from the Arabic *sukkar*, which comes from the Sanskrit *sharkara*. Sicily was one of the main routes by which sugar reached medieval Europe. Every time you eat a *cannolo*, you are at the end of an ingredient's journey from ancient India via the Arab world to a pastry counter in Catania. Your toddler, currently destroying a *granita* at high speed, is participating in civilisation.

1.3 The Sicilian Character

Sicilians are not quite like mainland Italians, and they know it. There is a particular combination of qualities you will encounter: warmth, pride, pragmatism, a certain philosophical calm in the face of difficulty, and an extremely well-developed sense of hospitality.

The last one matters most for your trip. You are travelling with a small child. In Sicily, this is an asset. Children are adored here — openly, effusively, without the northern European awkwardness about touching strangers' children. People will stop you in the street to admire your toddler. The waiter will bring something the child didn't order because he thought they might like it. The woman at the market will press a piece of fruit into small hands before you've had a chance to say anything. Accept all of this with grace and a smile. *Grazie mille*.

There is also the concept of *arrangiarsi* — literally "to arrange oneself," but really meaning the art of improvising, of finding a way through. Sicilians have been making do under difficult circumstances for a very long time. It produces a culture that is resourceful, flexible, and genuinely good at figuring things out on the fly. This is useful information if your car breaks down or you arrive at a restaurant to find it closed for a family celebration and the owner, instead of sending you away, seats you at the family table. This has been known to happen.

One practical note: Sicilian is spoken alongside Italian, and in older generations may be preferred. You will hear it in markets, between friends, and in animated telephone conversations. Standard Italian is universally understood and will serve you well. A few words of Sicilian — *beddu/bedda*

(beautiful, said constantly of small children), *mangiari* (to eat, something you will do a lot of) — will be received with delight out of proportion to the effort involved in learning them.

A note on the famous Sicilian fatalism: Living on an island that gets regularly shaken by earthquakes and has an active volcano visible from the city centre does something to your philosophy of life. Sicilians are not pessimistic — they are realistic in a way that has been earned over several thousand years of occupation, natural disaster, and the general difficulty of being Sicily. When something goes wrong, the response is rarely panic. It is usually a shrug, a coffee, and the question: what do we do now? This is an excellent travel mindset. Adopt it.

1.4 Why Catania? (And Not Palermo)

Every guide to Sicily eventually has to answer this question, so let's get it out of the way.

Palermo is Sicily's capital: bigger, grander, more famous, and the obvious choice if you are ticking boxes. It has extraordinary things — the Norman palace, the Cappella Palatina, the Ballarò market, the Teatro Massimo. If you have ten days and two cities, go to both.

But if you have one week and a toddler and a rental car, ****Catania is the better base****. Here's why.

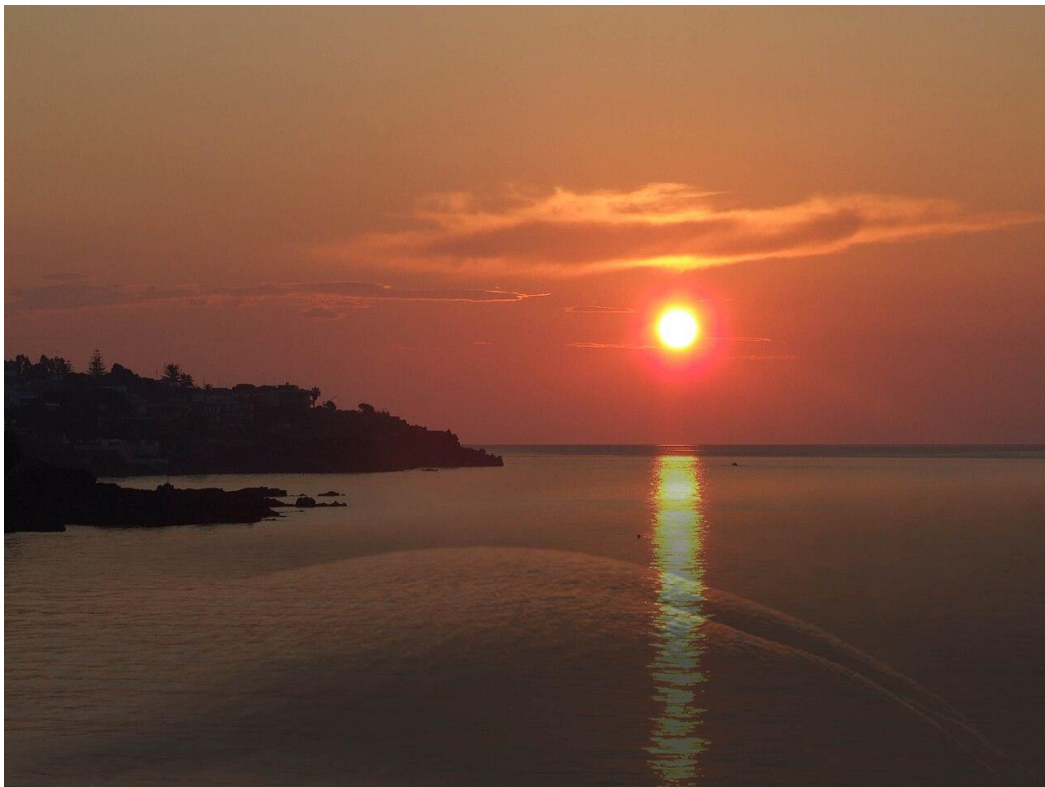
Position. Catania sits on the east coast, and from Catania you can reach Etna, Taormina, Syracuse, and the Cyclops coast all within an hour by car. The east coast has the best concentration of things to see. Palermo is on the other side of the island — beautiful things exist there too, but you would be driving two or three hours each way to reach most of what makes Sicily famous.

The airport. Catania Fontanarossa is one of the best-positioned airports in Italy: 5 km from the city centre, well-connected, easy to exit with a rental car. You will not waste a day navigating airport chaos.

The city itself. Catania is underrated in a way that Palermo no longer is. It is scrappier, rougher around the edges, less polished for tourists — and for exactly those reasons, more real. The market is extraordinary. The baroque

is UNESCO-listed and largely free to walk around. The street food is arguably better. The prices are noticeably lower. And because fewer first-time visitors put it on their list, you will find yourself in places that feel like they belong to the Catanesi rather than to you.

The volcano. Etna is visible from the city. Not in the vague "you might see mountains on the horizon" sense — on a clear day, from Via Etnea, you look north and there it is: a massive, snow-capped, occasionally smoking presence. The city is built on its lava. The cathedral is black with it. The pavements are made of it. Catania's entire character is shaped by living in the shadow of an active volcano, and that is fascinating in a way that no amount of excellent Norman architecture can replicate.



The lava city, briefly: Catania has been destroyed by Etna's eruptions multiple times. The great lava flow of 1669 reached the sea and added land to the coastline — Castello Ursino, which was once a coastal fortress, is now 2 km inland because of it. The city was then levelled by the 1693 earthquake. It was rebuilt, from scratch, in baroque, mostly using the same black basalt lava rock. There is something almost defiant about a city that uses the material that keeps destroying it to rebuild itself, over and over, into something more beautiful each time.

Next: Chapter 2 — Catania — City of Fire & Baroque

Chapter 2: Catania — City of Fire & Baroque

*"Catania is built on lava, destroyed by lava, and rebuilt in lava.
This is either terrifying or poetic, depending on your temperament.
The Catanesi have decided it is both."*

Most travel guides give Catania a paragraph and move on to Taormina. This is a mistake. Catania is one of the most distinctive cities in Italy — a baroque UNESCO World Heritage Site built entirely from the material that keeps trying to destroy it, with a fish market that is one of the great urban spectacles of southern Europe, a patron saint whose story makes *Game of Thrones* look restrained, and a symbolic elephant that has somehow become the most-loved civic emblem on the island. It deserves more than a paragraph.

Give it two full days. You won't regret it.

2.1 A City Built on Catastrophe

To understand Catania, you have to start with the worst eleven days in Sicilian history.

On the 9th of January 1693, a foreshock shook eastern Sicily. Two days later, on the 11th, the main earthquake hit — estimated at magnitude 7.4, still the most destructive earthquake ever recorded in Italian history. Entire cities collapsed. Catania was essentially levelled. An estimated 60,000 people died across the region, about 16,000 of them in Catania alone, in a city of roughly 20,000.

What happened next is the remarkable part.

Rather than abandon the ruins, the surviving Catanesi decided to rebuild. And not just to rebuild — to rebuild spectacularly. They had the cultural context for it: this was the height of the baroque era in Europe, and Spanish viceroys

controlled Sicily. The style of the moment was theatrical, ornate, and grand almost to the point of absurdity. The architects who descended on Catania — most notably Giovanni Battista Vaccarini — embraced it completely.

The result is a city centre that was essentially designed from scratch in a single sustained burst of creative ambition. The grid of wide streets (to allow better earthquake escape routes, a very practical consideration), the sweeping piazzas, the churches with their extravagant facades, the palaces with their carved lava stone balconies — all of it built within a few decades of the disaster. In 2002, UNESCO added Catania and the other Val di Noto baroque towns to the World Heritage List, recognising that this post-earthquake rebuilding represents one of the finest achievements of baroque urban planning.

The other thing they rebuilt with is the thing that keeps threatening to destroy them: volcanic basalt. Black lava stone is everywhere in Catania — the street paving, the church walls, the facades. When sunlight hits the golden limestone details against the dark volcanic stone, the whole city glows in a colour palette unlike anywhere else in Italy. This is Catania's signature look: black and gold, darkness and light, catastrophe and ornament.



2.2 The Elephant: Liotru, Symbol of Catania

Every city has a symbol. Rome has the she-wolf. Venice has the winged lion. Catania has an elephant — and the Catanesi will tell you, with complete seriousness, that the Liotru (the elephant's local name) is the oldest civic symbol still in continuous use in the world.

This may or may not be technically true. But the elephant has been on Catania's coat of arms since at least the Middle Ages, and the story behind it is wonderful.

The legend goes like this: Eliodoro (or Heliodorus) was a sorcerer who lived in Catania in the early centuries AD. He could transform himself into an elephant — or ride one, depending on which version you're told — and used this ability to terrorise the city. He was eventually defeated and driven out by Saint Agata's divine intervention. The locals adopted the elephant as a symbol, apparently deciding that a tamed version of the thing that once threatened them was exactly the kind of emblem they needed.

The elephant fountain in **Piazza del Duomo** is the centrepiece of the city. Designed by Vaccarini in 1736, it shows a small, almost goofy-looking elephant — carved from a single piece of ancient black lava, possibly pre-Roman — with an Egyptian obelisk balanced improbably on its back. The obelisk is topped with the symbols of Saint Agata. The whole construction is simultaneously absurd and magnificent.

Your toddler will love the elephant. They always do. It's the perfect height for pointing at and shouting about.



Liotru, officially: The name Liotru is a Sicilian corruption of Eliodoro, the sorcerer. So Catania's beloved elephant symbol is actually named after the villain of its own origin story. Catania: a city that turns its enemies into monuments. There's a lesson in there somewhere.

2.3 The Cathedral & Piazza del Duomo

Piazza del Duomo is the heart of Catania and one of the finest baroque piazzas in Italy. It's also genuinely useful as a meeting point, a place to sit with a coffee, and a landmark you can always navigate back to. Put it in your mental map now: when in doubt, head for the elephant.

The **Cathedral of Sant'Agata** closes the east side of the piazza. It was built over a Norman structure, which was built over a Roman bath complex, which was built over earlier foundations — Catania's habit of layering history is consistent. The baroque facade, completed in the 18th century, is imposing without being excessive, which is a harder balance to strike than it sounds.

Sant'Agata is Catania's patron saint, and her story is one of those early Christian martyr narratives that the medieval Church seemed to collect with some enthusiasm. The short version: Agata was a young Catanese noblewoman in the 3rd century AD who refused the advances of a Roman governor named Quintianus. He had her tortured. She died of her injuries around 251 AD, was canonised, and has been protecting Catania ever since — most notably, according to local tradition, turning back a lava flow with her veil shortly after her death.

The slightly longer version involves details that are decidedly not suitable for the toddler years. Wait until they're older.

The Agata Festival (3-5 February) is one of the largest religious festivals in Europe — regularly cited alongside the Holy Week in Seville as among the most intense in the Catholic calendar. For three days, an enormous silver reliquary bust of Sant'Agata is carried through the city streets by teams of men in white robes, accompanied by fireworks, candles, music, and roughly a million people. If your trip falls anywhere near February, this is extraordinary to witness.

Your March trip will just miss it — but the city's devotion to Agata is visible year-round in the many votive shrines, the cathedral itself, and the pastries: minnuzzi di Sant'Agata — small white marzipan cakes shaped like the saint's breasts — are sold in every pasticceria and are, despite the slightly challenging concept, delicious.

Stroller note: Piazza del Duomo is broad, flat, and paved — excellent push-chair territory. The cathedral interior has a smooth marble floor. This is one of the easiest areas of the city to navigate with a pram.

2.4 The Markets

La Pescheria — The Fish Market

Go early. Go on a weekday. Go before 10am if you can.

La Pescheria — the fish market — occupies a sunken piazza just behind the Cathedral, down a short flight of steps and through an arch. From the street above you might hear it before you see it: the shouts of vendors, the sound of ice being shovelled, the general controlled chaos of several dozen market stalls doing the most business they'll do all day.

What you will find inside is one of the great urban spectacles of southern Europe. Swordfish heads the size of a child's torso. Sea urchins split open on the spot, their vivid orange interior eaten raw from the shell with a piece of bread. Piles of sardines, anchovies, and small silver fish heaped on beds of crushed ice. Octopuses being manipulated with cheerful brutality. Tuna cut in great red slabs. Shellfish of every description. Vendors who have been doing this for decades and have elevated the sales pitch to a minor art form.

The colours — the silver of the fish, the orange of the urchin, the red of the tuna, the blue of the sea on tiled backsplashes — make it one of the most photographically rewarding places in the city. Come with a camera.

The market is at its best between 7am and 10am. By noon it is winding down; by 1pm it is gone, and the piazza becomes an ordinary square that gives almost no indication of what happened there four hours earlier.



Stroller note: La Pescheria is down a flight of steps from street level (there is usually a ramp or alternative access to the side — worth locating before you descend). Inside, the passages between stalls are narrow and can be slippery with water and ice. A pushchair is manageable but you'll be navigating carefully. Consider a carrier for the market itself, leaving the pushchair folded at the top.

Budget tip: The market is free to walk through and the spectacle costs nothing. Vendors along the edges sell boiled octopus, sea urchin on bread, and fried snacks — prices are low and the food is extraordinary. This is one of the best-value food experiences in Sicily.

Mercato di Via Plebiscito

Less famous than La Pescheria and better for it. This is where Catanesi actually do their weekly shopping — fruit, vegetables, cheeses, olives, dried goods, the occasional live chicken, all sold by vendors who are far more interested in their regulars than in tourists. Prices are lower, the atmosphere is calmer, and the produce is outstanding.

Good for: stocking up on picnic supplies, buying blood oranges by the kilo (they're grown near here and cost almost nothing), finding good local cheese to take home, and seeing an undramatised version of daily Catanian life.

The Markets of Catania

La Pescheria

Hours

Mon–Sat 6am–2pm

Best at

7–9am (busiest, best fish)

Buy

Fresh fish · sea urchin · clams
Octopus · swordfish · tuna

Eat

Boiled octopus · fried stall food
Street vendors at the edges

Stroller

★★★☆☆ Narrow in centre · carrier best

Tip

Arrive before 8am. The middle of the market is for professionals.

Mercato di Via Plebiscito

Hours

Mon–Sat 7am–2pm

Best at

9–11am (quieter, more relaxed)

Buy

Fruit · veg · herbs · spices
Blood oranges · lemons · capers

Eat

Less food at stalls — eat
before or after at nearby bars

Stroller

★★★★☆ Wider aisles, more manageable

Tip

Buy blood oranges in bulk here.
Cheaper than tourist spots.

2.5 Via Etnea & the Baroque Set Pieces

Via Etnea is Catania's main street, running north from Piazza del Duomo for about 2.5 km. It is also, on a clear day, one of the more dramatic urban vistas in Italy: stand at the southern end and look north, and Etna sits at the end of the avenue like a piece of scenery that is too large and too perfectly placed to be real.

Walk north along Via Etnea and you are walking through the baroque drawing room

of Catania. The important things to look at (not necessarily go inside, unless you want to — most are open and free):

The Collegiata — about 200m north of the piazza, on your right. An extraordinary facade with deeply carved figures that cast dramatic shadows. This is the building to photograph for the definitive "Catania baroque" image: black basalt plinth, white limestone columns, everything slightly too much in the best possible way.

The Benedictine Monastery — reached via a side street off Via Etnea (look for Via dei Crociferi first, a pedestrian street lined with baroque churches that looks like a film set). The Monastero dei Benedettini is one of the largest Benedictine monasteries ever built — it began construction in 1558,

was destroyed in the 1669 eruption, was rebuilt, was then destroyed in the 1693 earthquake, and was rebuilt again, larger, in the 18th century. It now houses the Faculty of Humanities of the University of Catania, which must make it the most beautiful university building in Italy. Guided tours are available and worth taking — they include the Arab-Norman remnants in the basement and the rooftop terrace with its view over the city.

Via dei Crociferi — a short pedestrian street running east off Via Etnea, flanked on both sides by baroque churches and palaces. Very photogenic, mildly chaotic with university students, and completely free. This is where the main Saint Agata festival procession passes in February, and the route is marked with plaques.

Piazza Bellini — named after Vincenzo Bellini, Catania's most famous son. The composer of *Norma* and *La Sonnambula* was born a few streets away in 1801. The piazza has his monument and also contains the **Greek-Roman Theatre** (see below). A good spot to stop for a coffee at one of the bars on the square — local prices, student crowd, good people-watching.

Stroller note: Via Etnea itself is mostly flat and has reasonable pavement width. The side streets — including Via dei Crociferi — are cobbled in lava stone, which can be uneven. A pushchair gets through, but it's not smooth going. Worth it.

2.6 The Roman Ruins

Catania was a significant Roman city, and the evidence is still there — you just have to know where to look, because it's been built around, built on top of, and incorporated into everything else.

The Roman Theatre and Odeon sit in the middle of a residential neighbourhood near Piazza Bellini, and the contrast is surreal and wonderful. The theatre is a proper Roman structure — 2nd century AD, capacity around 7,000 — with seating that has been partially excavated from under the buildings that were built directly on top of it over the centuries. The smaller Odeon next door was used for music and recitals. You can walk down into the theatre and see where medieval and baroque Catania was built literally on top of the ancient city.

The Amphitheatre at Piazza Stesicoro is even more disorienting. A large section of a Roman amphitheatre — second only to the Colosseum in scale in Italy when complete — sits partially exposed in the middle of a busy traffic roundabout in the city centre. You look down through a fence at Roman arches while cars circle above. The rest of it is under the piazza and the surrounding buildings. It's a striking reminder that Catania has been layering civilisations on top of each other for a very long time.

Budget tip: The Roman theatre has a small entrance fee (a few euros for adults; young children usually free — confirm on arrival). The amphitheatre at Piazza Stesicoro is visible for free from street level; the exposed section is modest but the context is striking. You don't need to pay to understand it.

2.7 Castello Ursino

At the southern edge of the historic centre, far enough from the main tourist drag to feel slightly forgotten, stands **Castello Ursino** — a Norman castle built by Holy Roman Emperor Frederick II in the 1230s.

When it was built, it sat on a promontory at the edge of the sea. Then the 1669 lava flow arrived, extended the coastline by about 800 metres, and left the castle stranded inland. It hasn't moved — Catania built around it instead. The castle's situation is now so perfectly illustrative of the city's relationship with Etna that it functions almost as a metaphor.

The exterior is imposing: thick Norman walls, four corner towers, a serious air of "do not bother us." Inside, the Civic Museum houses an eclectic collection — fragments of ancient sculpture, Egyptian artefacts, medieval stonework, paintings from various eras — which is engaging if you are in the mood for a museum, and rather dark and still if you are accompanied by an energetic toddler.

Practical verdict: The castle exterior and courtyard are worth visiting regardless. The museum is best tackled if you have a sleeping child in a pram or a very engaged adult who wants to spend real time in front of things. Not the first priority with a toddler in tow, but a good wet-weather option or late afternoon stop when the heat breaks.

Budget tip: Museum entrance is free on certain days — usually the first Sunday of the month and sometimes others, though this changes. Check the Comune di Catania website or ask at the tourist office on arrival. The courtyard is accessible independently of the museum.

On Catania's pace: Unlike Taormina (manicured, tourist-facing) or Syracuse (genteel, slightly self-conscious about its own beauty), Catania moves at its own rhythm and doesn't much care if you keep up. The streets are busy, the drivers are assertive, the market vendors are not waiting for you to finish reading the sign. This is not unfriendliness — it is just a city that is busy living rather than busy being visited. Once you adjust to the tempo, it is deeply energising. Give yourself a day to find your feet, and then lean in.

Next: Chapter 3 — Your Base — Practical Catania

Chapter 3: Your Base — Practical Catania

One rule for this trip: park the car, forget the car. Everything you need in Catania is on foot. The car is for day trips only. This decision alone will eliminate roughly 80% of potential holiday stress.

You are staying in the waterfront district, about 15–20 minutes on foot from the heart of the historic centre. This is the right call: you are close enough to walk everywhere that matters, far enough from the tourist scrum around the Duomo to feel like you are in a real neighbourhood. The fish market is about 15 minutes on foot. Piazza del Duomo is 20 minutes at a comfortable pace with a pushchair. The best bars and pasticcerie are within that radius. You will not be relying on the car to do anything in the city itself — and that is a relief, because central Catania is not designed for people who want to drive through it in a relaxed manner.

What follows is everything you need to know about operating out of your base before the day trips begin.

3.1 Getting Your Bearings

Catania's historic centre is compact in the best way. The main axis is **Via Etnea**, running north from Piazza del Duomo toward the volcano. Everything of note is either on this street or within a short walk of it. **Piazza del Duomo** — the elephant fountain — is your mental anchor point. When in doubt, navigate back to the elephant and reorient.

Key walking distances from Piazza del Duomo (roughly):

Destination	On foot from the piazza
La Pescheria fish market	3–5 min
Castello Ursino	15 min
Roman theatre	10 min
Benedictine Monastery	10 min
Villa Bellini (public park)	15 min
Best gelato on Via Etnea	8 min

From your apartment on Via Cristoforo Colombo, add roughly 15–20 minutes to each of these, heading north.

The city is largely flat in the centre, with some gentle slopes northward along Via Etnea. The main hazard underfoot is the lava-stone cobbling in the side streets — uneven, occasionally slippery when wet, and best negotiated with sensible shoes rather than the sandals you optimistically packed.



Historic Centre Walking Map

Piazza del Duomo → Via Crociferi → Benedictine Monastery

openstreetmap.org → search "Catania historic centre"

3.2 The Car: Park It and Mostly Forget It

You have the car. You will use it for every day trip. In the city, you will not use it at all if you can help it. Here's how to make that work.

Parking once and leaving it there

The ideal scenario: you arrive, you drive to your accommodation, you unload, you park the car in a nearby car park, and you do not see it again until the first day trip. The area around the historic centre has several options:

- **Parcheggio Borsellino** (Via Dusmet, near the waterfront): large, covered, close to the cathedral area. A solid choice for the whole week.
- **Piazza Cavour car park**: slightly north of the centre, easy access, reasonable rates.
- **On-street blue lines**: paid street parking, marked with blue lines. These work fine for short stays; for leaving the car all week, a proper car park gives more peace of mind.

Check with your accommodation — many hotels near the historic centre have an arrangement with a nearby garage, sometimes at a reduced rate. Ask when you book, or when you arrive.

ZTL: The Thing That Will Fine You Without Warning

This is important. Read it.

ZTL stands for Zona a Traffico Limitato — a Limited Traffic Zone.

Catania's historic centre has a ZTL that covers most of the streets around Piazza del Duomo and the baroque core. Cameras at the zone boundaries photograph your number plate automatically. If you drive into a ZTL without a permit, you will receive a fine in the post — typically €80-150 — weeks after you've forgotten the moment entirely. It is an extremely efficient system.

The key rules:

- **Do not drive through the centre to reach your hotel.** Ask your accommodation for instructions on how to approach from a permitted direction, or whether they have a ZTL exemption code for your plate.
 - **Loading and unloading is sometimes permitted** at restricted hours (often 7-10am) — again, ask your accommodation.
 - **Google Maps sometimes routes you through ZTL zones.** It does not know or care about the fine you will receive. Override it if you see you're heading into the old town by car.
 - When in doubt, park outside the zone and walk. Always the right answer.
-



ZTL Zone Map — Central Catania

Restricted traffic zones: check comune.catania.it for current boundaries

openstreetmap.org → search "Catania historic centre"

Driving the Day Trips

For each day trip, the practical driving notes are in the relevant chapter. But some general points about driving in Sicily that are worth having once:

The driving culture is best described as assertive rather than aggressive. Sicilian drivers are decisive, quick to fill gaps, and treat lane markings as helpful suggestions. They are not, in general, angry or confrontational — the driving style is more like a fast, fluid negotiation than the angry honking of, say, Rome or Naples. Relax your shoulders, match the pace, and you'll be fine within a day.

Roundabouts work on the principle that whoever is more committed to entering has priority. This is not what the Highway Code says. It is, nonetheless, how it works. Enter with confidence or wait for a clear gap.

Speed cameras are present on motorways and on some main roads. Indicated limits are enforced; the cameras are often signed in advance, which does not always leave enough stopping distance. Drive to the limit consistently rather than speeding between cameras.

The motorway (A18/A19): fast, well-maintained, tolled. Collect a ticket on entry, pay on exit. Keep a few euros in coins or a card in an accessible place. The toll amounts for your day trips are all modest (€2–5 each way).

3.3 Living in the Historic Centre

Staying central means the city's rhythms become your rhythms. Here's what those look like on a typical day:

Early morning (7-9am): the market is in full swing, the bars are doing their best business of the day. Get to La Pescheria before 10am at least once. Have your first granita con brioche standing at a bar counter, the way locals do. This is not breakfast as you know it. It is better.

Mid-morning (9-11am): the best time to walk, visit churches, and cover ground before the heat builds (even in March, midday can get warm). The piazzas are active but not yet crowded with tour groups.

Midday (12-3pm): this is riposo time in spirit if not always in practice. Many smaller shops close. The sensible approach with a toddler is to align the child's nap with this window — find shade, find a café, stop moving.

Afternoon (4-7pm): the city comes back to life. This is the time for the passeggiata — the early evening stroll that is a genuine social institution, not a tourist performance. Families, teenagers, elderly couples, all walking the same streets with no particular destination. Join in. Via Etnea and Piazza del Duomo are the main stages.

Evening (8pm onwards): dinner, in the Sicilian sense, does not start before 8pm. If you walk into a restaurant at 6:30pm, you will be seated, but you will be eating alone. The city's evening energy is real and late — even on weekdays, the streets around the baroque centre stay animated until midnight. With a toddler, you will probably not be part of this, but you can sit at an outdoor table and watch it happen over a glass of Etna Bianco.

Supplies and essentials within walking distance

Water: buy a large bottle (or two) from a supermarket and refill from it. Tap water in Catania is safe to drink. The street-level water fountains (nasoni) around the city also run constantly with fresh water — keep a small bottle and top up.

Supermarkets: there is a Lidl and a Carrefour within 10-15 minutes' walk of the historic centre. For fresh produce, the **Mercato di Via Plebiscito** (see Chapter 2) is both better and more interesting. Good for: fruit, blood oranges by the bag, local cheese, bread, snacks for the day trips.

Pharmacy: the green cross symbol. There is at least one within a few minutes of wherever you are in the historic centre. Hours are typically 9am-1pm and 4pm-8pm; most post a list of the nearest farmacia di turno (the one on overnight/emergency duty) in the window.

Baby supplies: nappies, wipes, formula — all available at supermarkets and some pharmacies. You do not need to pack for a siege. A few days' supply on arrival, then restock locally.

3.4 When It Rains

March in Catania brings some rain. Not constant, not all-day deluges as a rule — more likely short periods of real rain between stretches of bright cool weather. But it will happen, and it's worth having a plan that isn't "stare out of the window."

The good news: Catania is a much better rainy-day city than most guides suggest. Many of its best things are indoors or partially covered.

Best options when it rains, in rough order of recommendation:

A very long bar breakfast. Do not underestimate this. A good Catanian pasticceria on a rainy morning — minnuzzi di Sant'Agata, pistachio cornetti, sfogliatelle, granita, coffee — is one of the great indoor experiences of the trip. Take a newspaper or a book. Let the toddler eat their body weight in pastry. There is no rush.

The Benedictine Monastery (guided tour). Entirely indoors, genuinely spectacular, one of the most interesting spaces in the city. The tour takes you through the baroque state rooms, the underground Arab-Norman remnants, and up to the rooftop terrace (skip the terrace in heavy rain; the rest works fine). Book in advance — tours fill up.

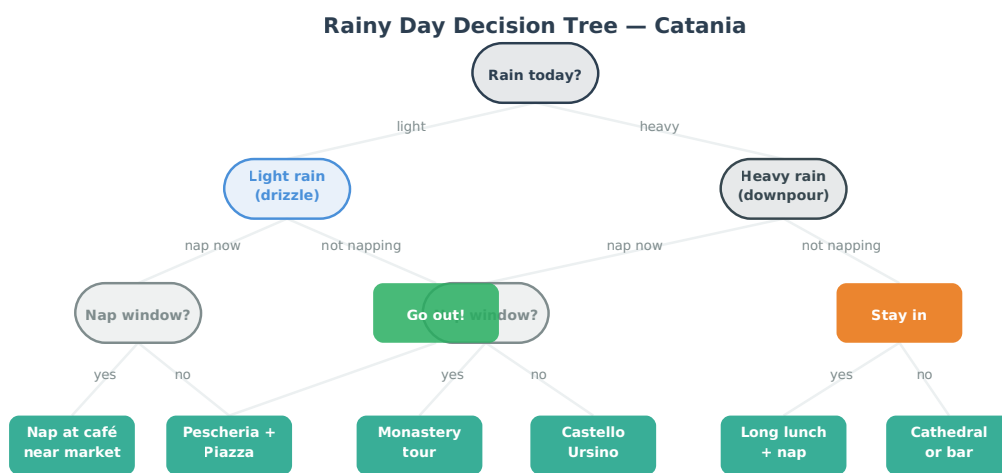
Castello Ursino and the Civic Museum. Dark, quiet, sheltered. Better in the rain than in glaring sunlight, honestly. Good for: the castle architecture, some interesting Greek pottery, a dry hour when the toddler is in the pushchair.

Palazzo Biscari. The finest private baroque palace in Catania, with a famous oval ballroom with frescoed ceiling. Tours run on specific days — check the schedule before your trip and try to book a rainy-day slot in advance. A treat for adults; manageable with a calm toddler.

The covered section of La Pescheria. Even in rain, the fish market operates and part of it is under cover. A rainy morning here is actually good — the light is different, there are fewer tourists, and the vendors are in an even better mood because they appreciate you showing up.

Drive to Ortigia. Counterintuitive for a rainy day, but Ortigia in the rain is beautiful — the pale limestone streets, the baroque cathedral, the covered market, the sense of an island shutting itself in. The drive is an hour; the reward is real. Pack an umbrella rather than skipping it.

Drive to the Paolo Orsi Archaeological Museum (Syracuse). If you're planning Syracuse as a day trip anyway (see Chapter 7), the Paolo Orsi museum — one of the finest archaeological museums in Europe — is entirely indoors and adjacent to the Neapolis park. A rainy Syracuse day can easily become a museum morning + Ortigia afternoon. Actually a great combination.



On Sicilian rain: locals treat rain with a mixture of mild irritation and philosophical acceptance. An umbrella appears from nowhere. The café fills up. Conversation continues. The market keeps going. There is no culture of cancelling plans because of weather — the Sicilian approach is to absorb it and carry on, which is, when you think about it, the right approach.

3.5 Toddler Logistics

Medical

Hospital: Ospedale Garibaldi Centro on Piazza Santa Maria di Gesù is the main central hospital, about 15 minutes on foot from the historic centre. For anything non-emergency, a pharmacy should be the first stop — Sicilian pharmacists are well-trained and willing to advise.

European Health Insurance Card (EHIC): bring it. It covers emergency treatment in Italian public hospitals without cost. If you don't have one, sort it before you travel — it takes minutes to apply online and the process is free.

Pharmacies near the centre: there are several on and around Via Etnea. The *farmacia di turno rota* (emergency cover) is posted in the window of every pharmacy — useful if you need something at 11pm.

Stroller Reality

The historic centre of Catania presents a tiered challenge for pushchairs, which this guide has been honest about throughout. To consolidate:

Green (smooth sailing):

- Piazza del Duomo and the immediate surroundings
- Via Etnea itself (the main street is paved, relatively smooth)
- Inside the cathedral and Castello Ursino courtyard
- The waterfront area

Amber (manageable, with care):

- The approach streets around La Pescheria (inside the market, step down with a ramp available)
- Most of the main pedestrian shopping streets
- Villa Bellini park (gravel paths but mostly level)

Red (carrier recommended):

- The lava-stone side streets in the old Arab quarter
- Via dei Crociferi (beautiful but uneven)
- The Roman theatre interior
- Anything described as "a lane" or "a vicolo"

The honest recommendation: bring a lightweight carrier as a backup. Not as a replacement for the pushchair — the pushchair is essential for nap-time logistics — but as an alternative for the 20-minute stretches where the pushchair becomes more hindrance than help. The carrier packs small. Use both, depending on terrain.



Stroller-Friendly Route Map

Green: smooth pavements · Amber: cobblestones · Red: steps only

openstreetmap.org → search "Catania historic centre"

Next: Chapter 4 — Day by Day — Your Week

Chapter 4: Day by Day — Your Week

14–20 March 2026

This is a suggested itinerary, not a contract. Things will go sideways. The toddler will have opinions. It will rain on a day you planned for the beach. A restaurant will be closed for a cousin's wedding. Embrace all of it. The best travel moments are usually the unplanned ones — and Sicily is very good at producing them.

The Setup

You arrive: Saturday 14 March, evening.

You leave: Friday 20 March, at the airport by ~1pm (allow for a 12:30pm departure from the apartment; the airport is 10 minutes away by car from your address).

Your apartment: Via Cristoforo Colombo 20, 95121 Catania. Waterfront district, between the historic centre and the port. Piazza del Duomo is about 15–20 minutes on foot heading north. The airport is 10 minutes by car heading south. A practical base in all directions.

Your group: 2 adults + 2 grandparents + 1 toddler — five people, all travelling together, all days. The grandparents are comfortable walkers but prefer flat terrain and a paced rhythm — no forced marches, no long staircase climbs, no hours on uneven volcanic rock. This is completely workable and is already woven into how each day below is structured.

One logistical flag — the car: Five people plus luggage for a full week is tight in a standard 5-seater rental car. If the car booked is a compact or mid-size, you may want to upgrade to a larger vehicle (estate/MPV) before the trip — day trips will involve the full group plus everything needed for a toddler and a day out. Worth confirming this with the rental company now rather than at the pickup desk.

Your actual days:

Date	Day	Status
Sat 14 Mar	Day 1	Arrive evening
Sun 15 Mar	Day 2	Full day
Mon 16 Mar	Day 3	Full day
Tue 17 Mar	Day 4	Full day
Wed 18 Mar	Day 5	Full day
Thu 19 Mar	Day 6	Full day
Fri 20 Mar	Day 7	Morning only — depart ~12:30pm

The Actual Weather Forecast

Let's be honest about this upfront, because the forecast changes everything about how the week should be ordered.

Date	Forecast	Rain chance
Sat 14 Mar	Afternoon showers — you arrive in the evening	62%
Sun 15 Mar	Showers, breezy	87%
Mon 16 Mar	Downpours in the afternoon, windy	90%
Tue 17 Mar	Afternoon showers, rain overnight	90%
Wed 18 Mar	Downpours in the afternoon	80%
Thu 19 Mar	Partly sunny ☀️	13%
Fri 20 Mar	Morning shower, then rain	85%

Source: [AccuWeather Catania](https://www.accuweather.com/en/it/catania/215605/weather-forecast/215605) (<https://www.accuweather.com/en/it/catania/215605/weather-forecast/215605>)

(Forecasts beyond 7–10 days carry uncertainty — check again a few days before travel, but plan on the basis of this for now.)

The headline: Thursday 19 March is the only genuinely clear day of the week, and it is therefore the day for **Etna**. Non-negotiable. Etna in cloud and rain is not Etna.

The pattern for Sunday-Wednesday: rain is predominantly in the afternoons ("afternoon showers", "downpours in the pm"). This is the key piece of information. Mornings are often better than afternoons. Day trips should depart early, do the outdoor sections in the morning, and be indoors or heading home by the time the afternoon rain builds. This is workable.

Friday morning: 85% chance of a morning shower, but you're departing at 12:30pm. Market run early, back to pack by 11am, drive to airport — the rain is an inconvenience, not a crisis.

How to Read This Chapter

Each day is built around two fixed priorities: protecting the midday window (roughly 12:30–3pm) for the toddler's nap, and getting outdoor activities done in the morning before the afternoon rain arrives. These two things happen to coincide almost perfectly this week, which is fortunate.

The car stays parked on city days. On day trips, you leave early — 7:30am as a rule — to front-load the outdoor portions before the weather turns.

Each day entry is structured the same way:

Morning	Best hours — the outdoor window before rain builds
Midday	Nap window — strategic stillness
Afternoon	Covered or indoor options; outdoor if it has cleared
Evening	Passeggiata, aperitivo, dinner at Sicilian time
Ratings	Stroller friendliness · Budget · Exertion level

Saturday 14 March — Arrive & Find Your Feet

62% rain in the afternoon — you arrive in the evening. This is fine.

You have driven from the airport with luggage and a toddler who has been on a plane. Via Cristoforo Colombo 20 is ten minutes from the airport by car. Check in, drop the bags, park the car.

Evening

If the rain has eased by the time you arrive and settle: walk north for 15 minutes toward **Piazza del Duomo** for a first look. The elephant fountain in the evening is a good introduction. Or don't — it's a rainy Saturday and you've just arrived. The piazza will still be there tomorrow.

Find a restaurant within easy walking distance of the apartment. Something simple, close, no heroics. Pizza is legitimate on a first wet evening in Sicily and Sicily does it well.

Tonight: look at the forecast for the week, absorb the fact that Thursday is your clear day, and let the rest of the planning follow from that.

Stroller	Budget	Exertion
★★★★ Evening waterfront streets, flat	€ — One meal	Minimal — arrival day

Sunday 15 March — Deep Catania

87% rain. Showers, breezy. This is a Catania day — and Catania handles rain better than you'd expect.

The good news: most of what makes Catania's city experience extraordinary is either indoors or partially covered. The fish market operates in rain.

The baroque facades are, if anything, more dramatic when wet — the black lava stone deepens in colour and the carved limestone takes on a sheen.

This is not a wasted day. It is a different kind of Catania day.

Morning (earlier is drier — aim to be out by 8am)

La Pescheria, the fish market. Rain does not stop the market. The vendors are there, the fish is there, the chaos is there. Part of the market is under cover; the rest gets wet along with everyone else. Take the carrier for the toddler inside (narrow, wet underfoot). Eat something from the edge vendors — fried things, boiled octopus, whatever is in your hand before you've made a decision.

From the market, head to **Piazza del Duomo** — the elephant fountain in the rain, the cathedral facade. Then decide whether to shelter or walk.

If it's light rain: Via dei Crociferi (the baroque side street — manageable under an umbrella, worth it), and the exterior of the ****Benedictine Monastery**** facade.

If it's heavy: inside the **Cathedral of Sant'Agata** — free, large, quiet. The baroque interior holds up for 20–30 minutes without needing to be an art historian.

Midday

Lunch near **Piazza Bellini** — university area, honest pricing, indoor seating. Long lunch. Nap at the table or back at the apartment.

Afternoon

This is when Sunday's rain is worst. Plan for indoor options:

Benedictine Monastery tour (if you booked in advance — worth doing for a wet afternoon). Two hours, entirely indoors, one of the most extraordinary spaces in the city. The tour covers the baroque state rooms, the Arab-Norman remnants in the basement, and the rooftop terrace (skip the terrace today).

Castello Ursino if the monastery isn't available. The Norman castle interior is dark and quiet; good for an hour when it's raining outside.

Alternative: do not fight the afternoon rain. Go back to the apartment, make tea, let the toddler play, look at the wet street. This is also a completely valid use of a wet Sunday afternoon in Sicily.

Evening

Aperitivo if the rain eases (it may — the forecast says showers, not continuous rain). A bar with a covered terrace, something local to drink, watching the Catanesi manage the weather with characteristic indifference.

Dinner nearby, early enough for the toddler.

The Sicilian rain approach: the locals carry an umbrella and continue. There is no culture of cancelling plans due to weather. The cafés fill up. The market continues. The passeggiata moves a little faster. Match the energy.

Stroller	Budget	Exertion
★★★★☆ Market is tricky; cathedral and piazza fine	€€ — monastery tour + lunch	Low-medium — indoor-focused day

Monday 16 March — Syracuse & Ortigia

90% rain, downpours in the afternoon, windy. Go early, be indoors by afternoon.

Syracuse is the right day trip for a wet day, and here is why: the best of Syracuse comes in two parts — the open-air **Neapolis Archaeological Park** in the morning, and **Ortigia** (the island old town) in the afternoon.

The park is weather-sensitive; Ortigia is not. The plan: do the park in the morning before the afternoon downpours arrive, and let the rain come while you're already on Ortigia with its covered streets and café tables.

Morning (leave the apartment by 7:30am — this early start matters today)

Drive south on the A19 motorway — 1 hour from Catania. From Via Cristoforo Colombo, you are already pointing roughly southward; the initial stretch toward the airport is familiar ground from arrival day.

Park at the **Neapolis Archaeological Park** entrance. Do the outdoor section now, while the morning is on your side:

- **The Greek Theatre** (5th century BC, one of the best preserved in the world — see Chapter 7 for the full account). Sit at the top of the seating tiers. Allow a moment.
- **The Roman Amphitheatre** immediately adjacent. The contrast between what the Greeks and Romans chose to build for public entertainment is worth looking at directly.
- **The Ear of Dionysius** — the cave Caravaggio named, where a whisper at one end is audible at the other. Take the toddler to the far end and whisper. This is a legitimate use of 2,300 years of architecture.

A note for the grandparents in the Neapolis park: the main paths between the Greek theatre, the Roman amphitheatre, and the Ear of Dionysius are gravel — uneven in places, but walkable at a measured pace with good shoes. The Greek theatre seating is cut stone tiers with no handrail; going partway up is fine and gives the view. The Ear of Dionysius cave is flat-floored and easy.

The **Paolo Orsi Museum** alternative (see below) is entirely indoors and flat — a good fallback if the park terrain is too much in the wet.

Aim to be done with the park by noon, before the afternoon rain builds.

If it's already raining heavily on arrival: go directly to the ****Paolo Orsi Archaeological Museum**** instead — one of the finest archaeological museums in Europe, entirely indoors, immediately adjacent to the park entrance. Covers the same ground as the park through extraordinary objects. Allow 2 hours. Also the right call if the grandparents find the park terrain difficult in the wet.

Midday

Cross to **Ortigia** — 10 minutes by car. Lunch in the streets behind the waterfront (not the obvious tourist restaurants on Piazza Archimede — one lane back, where the prices and quality improve). The **Ortigia market** on Via Trento may still be running if you arrive before noon.

Nap on the Ortigia waterfront — benches facing the sea, the pram doing its work. One of the better nap-window locations of the week, and in the rain, the harbour has a particular quiet to it.

Afternoon

Walk Ortigia in the rain. This is not a hardship.

The Cathedral — built into a Greek temple, the original Doric columns still visible inside the baroque church. Free to enter. The interior is warm and dry and extraordinary.

The Fountain of Arethusa — a natural freshwater spring at the southern tip of the island, papyrus plants growing at the edge of the sea. Worth seeing in any weather; the rain gives the stone a different quality.

Aperitivo on the waterfront if it eases toward 5pm. If not: a bar with indoor seating, a glass of Nero d'Avola, and the satisfaction of having had a full Syracuse day in difficult weather.

Evening

Drive back — 1 hour. Dinner near the apartment, simple and close. An early evening after a long day.

Stroller	Budget	Exertion
★★★☆☆ Ortigia excellent; park gravel paths harder in rain	€€ — entrance fees + lunch	Medium — a long day, managed well

Tuesday 17 March — Taormina

90% rain, afternoon showers. Go very early. Be at the theatre before the clouds settle.

This is the difficult call of the week. Taormina at 90% rain is not the same as Taormina on a clear day — the famous view from the Greek theatre (stage arch, sea, Etna behind) depends on visibility that rain can eliminate. But Taormina in light rain, with fewer tourists and the town quieter than in any other conditions, has its own appeal.

The strategy: leave early enough to be at the theatre by 9am, when it opens and before the worst of the day typically arrives. Do the outdoor sections in the morning window. Be back on the Corso for lunch, where rain is manageable. Drive back before the afternoon downpours.

If the morning forecast on Tuesday specifically looks like heavy cloud from the start, reconsider. Swap Tuesday and Wednesday (coast day Tuesday, Taormina Wednesday) and see if one morning is better than the other. Both are wet; choose the less wet one for Taormina.

Morning (leave the apartment by 7am — earlier than usual)

A18 motorway north — 50 minutes. Park at **Mazzarò** (lower car parks at the base of the cliff), take the **funivia** cable car up. The cable car in rain: perfectly fine, and the views going up through mist have a drama of their own.

A note for the grandparents in Taormina: the cable car up is fine for everyone. At the top, the **Corso Umberto** is flat, smooth, and entirely comfortable. The approach into the Greek theatre involves a short walk on uneven ancient stone, with some steps. Entirely manageable at a steady pace; no need to rush. The upper seating tiers (the best viewpoint) involve a further climb — the grandparents can sit at the lower orchestra level and still see the stage, the sea arch, and the Etna backdrop. The ****Piazza IX Aprile terrace and Villa Comunale**** gardens are both flat and easy.

Teatro Greco-Romano first, immediately, while the morning is on your side. The theatre opens at 9am. In rain, the tour groups are smaller, the space is quieter, and the stage-sea-Etna composition — even if Etna is partly cloud-covered — is still moving. Rain has a way of making ancient ruins feel more ancient. The upper tiers are exposed to weather; the theatre is not. Dress for it.

After the theatre: **Piazza IX Aprile** (the great terrace viewpoint — even in cloud, the coastline view is striking). **Villa Comunale** (the English gardens — sheltered paths, a toddler run-around in light rain).

Midday

Lunch just off the Corso Umberto, under a proper roof. Long lunch. If it's raining hard: this is now an indoor afternoon. The **Corso** itself is walkable under umbrellas, and the ceramics shops are warm and dry.

Nap in a café, or in the car on the drive back.

Afternoon

Drive back by 3pm — before the afternoon deteriorates further and the A18 southbound traffic from Taormina builds.

Evening

An easy evening — the day was enough. Aperitivo near the apartment, dinner nearby.

If Tuesday morning looks genuinely terrible (heavy cloud, zero visibility):

swap to the coast alternative below and try Taormina on Wednesday when the rain drops to 80%. Neither day is ideal; the morning window is the only variable you can control.

Stroller	Budget	Exertion
★★☆☆☆ Carrier needed for theatre; Corso manageable	€€€ — parking + funivia + tourist-town prices	Medium — clifftop walking in wet weather

Wednesday 18 March — The Coast

80% rain, downpours in the afternoon. Morning coastal visit, indoor afternoon.

80% is still a lot of rain, but it's the lowest number between Sunday and Thursday. And the coast trip — Aci Trezza, Aci Castello, the Cyclops sea stacks — is the most rain-resistant of the remaining day trips. The sea

stacks look dramatic in any weather. Aci Castello on its basalt rock over a grey sea is a genuinely different kind of impressive. And **Acireale** (10 minutes further north) is entirely manageable in rain.

Morning (leave the apartment by 9am — this is a short drive)

Drive north along the coastal road from the apartment — the sea immediately to your right. **Aci Trezza** is 20 minutes away, no motorway, no toll.

The **Faraglioni** (the Cyclops sea stacks) from the harbour in the rain: the basalt columns rise out of grey water under low cloud, and the mythological weight of the place — Polyphemus hurling them at Odysseus — feels more real, not less. Walk the waterfront. Get a coffee. Let the child run at the sea if it's only light rain.

From Aci Trezza, drive 10 minutes south to **Aci Castello** — the Norman castle balanced on its basalt platform over the sea. The exterior in rain is dramatic. Go up if the toddler's energy allows.

Midday

Seafront trattoria in Aci Trezza — the fish was in the water this morning. Order whatever the waiter recommends. House white, cold. Nap in the pram along the sheltered part of the waterfront.

Afternoon

Two directions depending on how the afternoon rain develops:

If light rain: continue up the coast to **Acireale** (10 minutes further north from Aci Trezza). A small baroque city on the clifftop — mostly ignored by tourists and entirely worth an hour. The piazza, the cathedral, the excellent pasticceria. The belvedere over the coast if the weather allows. Completely manageable in the wet.

If heavy rain: drive back to Catania (20 minutes) and call the afternoon a rest day. You've had the coast; you've had the sea stacks; the rain wins the afternoon. Go to the apartment, make tea, read something.

Evening

An easy evening — you've earned it after three days of navigating rain. Aperitivo, something good for dinner. You have Etna tomorrow.

Stroller	Budget	Exertion
★★★★☆ Good along the waterfront; rock platforms need a carrier	€ — Cheaper eating, no entrance fees	Low — the rest day in a rainy week

Thursday 19 March — Mt Etna

13% rain. Partly sunny. This is your day.

This is why the whole week has been ordered this way. Thursday is the only clear day of the week. Etna gets it. Every other day trip was chosen partly for its rain-resilience, specifically to save this day for the volcano. Go.

Etna with the full group — an honest plan

The classic Etna experience — cable car to 2,500m, then 4x4 jeep to 2,900m on raw lava terrain, then a walk across volcanic rock to the crater viewing area — is a specific kind of physically demanding. The jeep ride is rough. The terrain above the cable car is uneven and wind-exposed. For grandparents who prefer a paced, flat day, the upper mountain is too much.

The good news: **Etna is extraordinary at multiple altitudes**, and the lower slopes — specifically the lava fields accessible by road around 1,500–1,800m — are dramatic, strange, and entirely achievable for everyone in the group. Here is how to structure the day so that nobody misses out:

Option A — Split approach (recommended):

Drive to **Rifugio Sapienza** (1,900m, the cable car base) together. The grandparents have coffee at the Rifugio Sapienza restaurant — which has terrace views over the lava landscape and is entirely comfortable — while the younger adults take the toddler up via cable car. The cable car ride itself (15 minutes each way) offers views of the upper mountain and the Sicilian coastline below; the summit zone (from the upper station, it's a short walk or optional jeep ride) is the toddler's carrier experience, not the grandparents'. You are gone for 2–3 hours maximum; the grandparents have a front-row seat to the lava landscape and the mountain scenery from the Rifugio terrace. Reunite for lunch.

This only works if "full group always together" allows for 2–3 hours in the same general location but not the same activity. If so, it is the right answer.

Option B — Lava fields walk for everyone:

Drive up the road to Rifugio Sapienza but skip the cable car entirely. Instead, park and walk into the **2001 and 2002 lava flows** on the south slope — accessible from the road, on relatively level lava terrain, free, and still genuinely extraordinary. The scale of what you're walking on (frozen rivers of black rock, kilometres of lava that moved down this slope within days) is impressive at any altitude. The views from 1,800m on a clear day already include the Sicilian coastline and the Strait of Messina. This is absolutely an Etna day — just not the summit crater version. And it works for everyone, toddler in the pushchair on the flatter lava tracks, grandparents walking at their own pace.

Our recommendation: Option A if grandparents are comfortable with the 2–3 hours at the Rifugio terrace. Option B if you want to genuinely stay together throughout. Either way, everyone arrives at the same lunch table having seen Etna in its full clear-day glory.

Morning (leave the apartment by 7:30am)

Drive south — airport direction — then inland through **Nicolosi** to Rifugio Sapienza. 45 minutes from Via Cristoforo Colombo. The road through Nicolosi is winding and slow in the final section.

Book the cable car in advance if going up — the first clear day after a rainy week may see a rush. Check [funiviaetna.com](https://www.funiviaetna.com) (<https://www.funiviaetna.com>) for tickets and opening status.

Layers on everyone — the mountain is significantly colder than Catania. At 1,900m (Rifugio Sapienza level) it could easily be 6–8°C with wind. At 2,500m (cable car top), colder still. A warm jacket for every person, including the toddler.

Midday

Reunite at Rifugio Sapienza by noon, then drive down to **Zafferana Etnea** on the eastern slope for lunch — local trattorias, the honey the village is famous for, a pleasant stop before the drive back. Nap in the car on the return.

Afternoon

Back at the apartment by 2:30–3pm. Keep it easy. The clear weather is an invitation to walk along the waterfront — the volcano visible to the north on a day like this from the seafront near the apartment, a completely different view of it from sea level.

This is your last full evening. The farewell dinner tonight, at a restaurant you've identified during the week as the right place for this group, for this occasion. A full Sicilian meal — antipasto, primo, secondo, dolce. A bottle of Etna Rosso, earned literally and thematically. Cannoli at the end, filled to order, the shell shattering.

Then the passeggiata. Via Etnea, the elephant fountain, the volcano in the dark — and today you know exactly what's up there. Go to bed late. It's your last proper night.

Stroller	Budget	Exertion
★★★☆☆ Option A: carrier for cable car sections; Option B: pushchair workable on lava tracks	€€€ cable car / € lava fields walk	Option A: high for the younger adults, low for grandparents at Rifugio / Option B: low-medium for everyone

Friday 20 March — The Morning Before the Airport

85% chance of a morning shower. Depart the apartment by 12:30pm.

The airport is 10 minutes by car. Leave at 12:30, arrive at 12:40, done. That gives you from 8am to 12pm — four hours for a last morning in Catania. Don't waste it by trying to do too much.

Morning (8am–noon)

Option A — The market one last time:

Walk to **La Pescheria** (15 minutes). A Friday market in the rain has a particular atmosphere — focused, local, functional. Go back, even if you've been before. You see it differently the second time. Then ****Mercato di Via Plebiscito**** for last-minute food shopping: blood oranges by the kilo (buy aggressively — they barely survive the journey but the ones that make it home are extraordinary), pistachio cream, dried oregano, capers, anything you meant to buy earlier in the week and didn't.

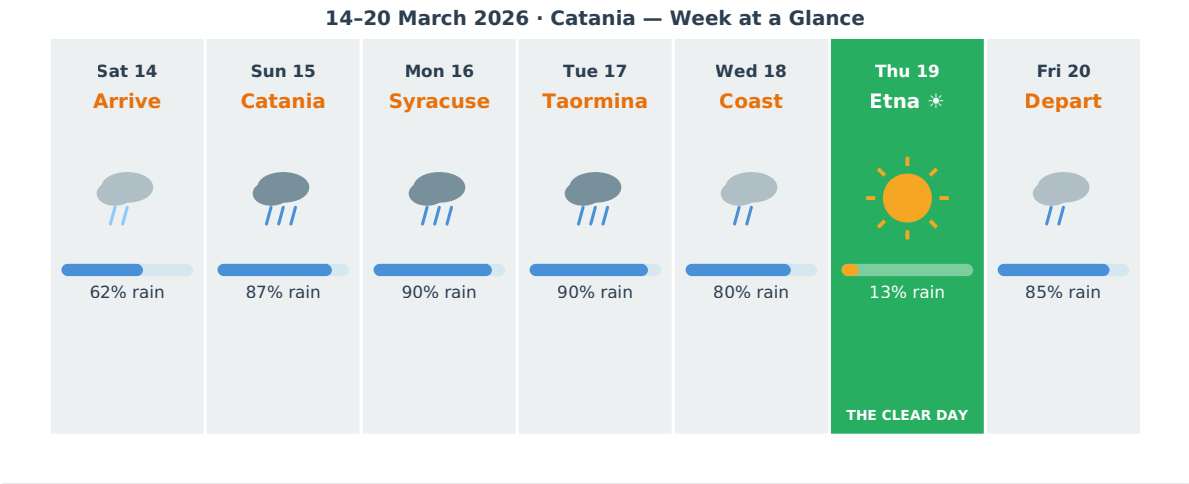
Option B — Slow bar breakfast:

Find the bar you've come to love. Order everything. Take your time. Let the toddler eat. Look at the wet street. Read nothing.

Either way: back to the apartment by 11am. Pack. Load the car. Check behind the bathroom mirror for the charger. Drive to the airport at 12:30pm.

The terminal at Catania Fontanarossa has a bar. Order one last arancino before you go through security. It will not be as good as the ones from La Pescheria. Order it anyway.

Stroller	Budget	Exertion
★★★★★ Familiar streets, familiar rhythm	€ — Market shopping and breakfast	Minimal — this morning is for being, not doing



Why this order: Thursday is the only clear day, so Etna gets Thursday. Everything else was chosen and sequenced for its rain-resilience: Syracuse on Monday (Ortigia works in rain, Paolo Orsi museum is fully indoors), Taormina on Tuesday (go at 7am, do the theatre before the clouds settle, use the Corso and indoor shops for the afternoon), coast on Wednesday (Aci Castello in rain is dramatic; Acireale is fully manageable in wet). Sunday is the deep Catania day — the city's indoor riches are substantial, and a rainy Sunday in the fish market and the Benedictine Monastery is a genuinely excellent day.

On the grandparents throughout: the flattest and most comfortable days for them are Sunday in Catania (piazza, cathedral, monastery — all manageable), Monday in Ortigia (the smoothest streets of any day trip), and Wednesday on the coast (flat waterfront promenade). Taormina involves some uneven stone at the theatre — manageable, not demanding. Etna is the day that needs the most thought, and the split approach (Rifugio Sapienza terrace + cable car for the younger adults) is the honest solution.

Check the forecast daily. The percentages will shift. But the logic holds: protect Thursday for Etna no matter what, and let everything else flex around the weather as it comes.

Next: Chapter 5 — Day Trip: Mt Etna

Chapter 5: Day Trip — Mt Etna

"Etna is not a mountain with a volcano in it. Etna is the volcano. The mountain is just what happens when a volcano has been erupting in the same place for half a million years."

You can see Etna from the city. On a clear morning, standing at the north end of Via Etnea, you look up the long straight avenue and there it is — filling the end of the street like a painting of itself, the summit trailing a thin white plume of steam and gas against the blue sky. It has been doing this for as long as there have been people in Catania to look at it.

This is the most extraordinary thing about Etna: it is not remote. It is not a volcano you fly to see. It is the backdrop to daily life for the entire east coast of Sicily. Catanesi grew up looking at it. Farmers grow wine grapes and pistachios on its slopes. Villages have been built, buried, evacuated, and rebuilt on its flanks for three thousand years. The locals have a relationship with the mountain that is less about awe and more about coexistence — the volcano is a neighbour, not a spectacle.

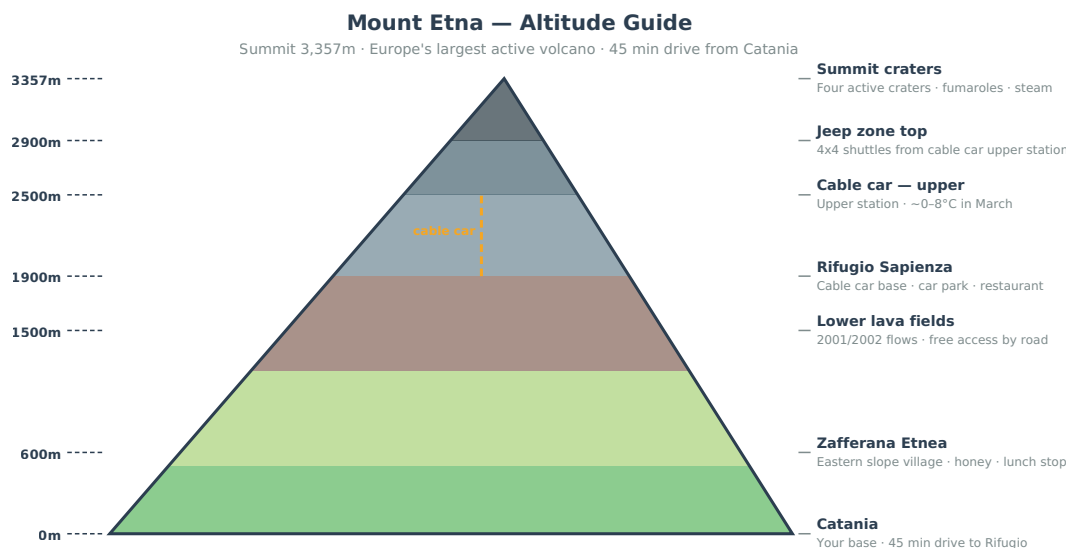
You are going to visit your neighbour.

5.1 Understanding the Volcano

Etna is the largest active volcano in Europe: 3,357 metres at the summit, covering approximately 1,190 square kilometres of the eastern Sicilian landscape. It has four summit craters, all of which can be active simultaneously, and dozens of secondary vents scattered across the flanks. It erupts with some regularity — sometimes mildly (a quiet lava flow, a plume of ash), sometimes dramatically (the eruptions of 2001 and 2002 were significant enough to threaten the cable car infrastructure and close roads).

This is not alarming. Etna is a well-monitored, well-studied volcano and the authorities take no chances with public safety — the cable car and summit access are closed if there is any real risk to visitors. If you are able to go up, it is safe to go up. What you will find there is not danger but strangeness: a landscape of frozen lava flows, steaming craters, and mineral-stained rock in colours — ochre, red, white, black — that seem to belong to a different planet.

The slopes tell the story of centuries of eruptions in their landscape. The lower flanks are green and fertile — the volcanic soil is extraordinarily rich, which is why the wine and the pistachios and the honey from Etna are so distinctive. As you climb, the vegetation thins and then stops. Above 2,000m it is bare rock, snow in winter and spring, and the wind. Above 2,500m — where the cable car takes you — it is another world entirely.



5.2 Getting There

From central Catania, the drive to the cable car base station takes about 45 minutes. The route goes south through the city and then turns inland, climbing through the outer suburbs and into the lava landscape of the southern slope. The road through **Nicolosi** — the main gateway village on the south side — is well-signed. From Nicolosi to **Rifugio Sapienza** (the cable car base, at around 1,900m) is a further 15 kilometres of winding mountain road that narrows as it climbs.

The car park at Rifugio Sapienza is large and generally manageable in March, before the main tourist season. In July and August it fills early — another reason the timing of your trip works in your favour.

Driving notes for this route:

- The approach road from Nicolosi to Rifugio Sapienza is winding, with hairpin bends. Not technically difficult, but takes longer than the map suggests — add time.
 - There is a toll on the A18 motorway if you use it to leave Catania southward; the alternative is the state road through the suburbs, slower but free.
 - Fuel up before leaving Catania. There is no petrol station at altitude.
-

5.3 Your Options on the Mountain

There is no single right way to visit Etna. The right way depends on how high you want to go, how much you want to spend, and how much the toddler is going to cooperate with being carried at altitude in the cold. Here are the three honest options:

Option A: Cable Car + 4x4 Jeep (Recommended)

The **Funivia dell'Etna** runs from Rifugio Sapienza (1,900m) to the upper mountain station at around 2,500m. The journey takes roughly 15 minutes each way and the views from the cable car — looking back down over the lava fields and the Sicilian coastline — are themselves worth the ticket.

From the upper cable car station, authorised 4x4 jeep shuttles take visitors up to approximately 2,900m, to the area around the summit craters. This is the jeep ride that most visitors remember: rough lava terrain, the vegetation entirely gone, the crater rims visible above you, the whole of eastern Sicily spread below. The experience at 2,900m — the crater views, the steam, the sulphur smell, the lunar texture of the lava — is unlike anything on the rest of this trip.

Practical notes:

- Book the cable car online in advance, especially in spring and summer. In March it may be fine without booking; check the official Funivia website before you go.

- The jeep shuttles run from the upper cable car station independently and can be booked or joined at the top.
- The round trip (cable car + jeep) typically takes 3–4 hours from Rifugio Sapienza.
- **The pushchair does not go above the cable car base station.** Leave it folded in the car or at the base. From the cable car onward, the toddler goes in the carrier.
- At 2,900m, the wind is real and the temperature is genuinely cold. Dress accordingly — warm layers for the whole family, regardless of what the weather in Catania was doing that morning.

Option B: Guided Tour from Catania

Multiple operators run half-day and full-day tours from Catania to Etna. These typically involve minibus pickup from a central meeting point, a guide, and either the cable car or access to the lower mountain via jeep track. Some include tastings at Etna wineries on the descent.

The advantage: zero logistics. Someone else figures out the parking, the cable car queues, the jeep timing. The guide provides context that makes the landscape much more readable — having someone explain what you're looking at, which lava flow is from which eruption, why the rock is that colour, makes the experience significantly richer.

The disadvantage: you're on someone else's schedule, which with a toddler can be complicated.

Who this works for: families who want to focus on the experience rather than the logistics, or who find the mountain-driving prospect stressful. A good guide makes Etna considerably more than a cable car ride and some rocks.

Option C: Drive Up and Walk the Lava Fields (Free)

This is the undersung option that most guides don't mention because it doesn't involve any bookable products.

The lava flows from the significant eruptions of 2001 and 2002 are visible and accessible from the road that climbs toward Rifugio Sapienza. You can pull over, walk into the lava fields, and spend an hour exploring frozen rivers of black rock, lava tubes, and the eerie landscape of a

recent eruption — all for free, at around 1,500–1,800m altitude, well within the range of a toddler on foot or in a pushchair on reasonable terrain.

This is not the summit experience. You are not seeing craters or steaming fumaroles at close range. But the scale of the lava flows — the sheer volume of rock that moved down this slope in a matter of days — is extraordinary, and the landscape at this altitude already feels genuinely alien. For families with a toddler who is too young to appreciate the upper mountain, and for budget-conscious travellers, this is a real and valid way to experience Etna.

5.4 What It's Actually Like Up There

The cable car departs from the edge of the Rifugio Sapienza car park. The lower section ascends through a landscape of old lava flows and scrubby vegetation; the upper section leaves the vegetation behind entirely and moves through bare, wind-scoured rock. By the time you reach the upper station, the world below — Catania, the coast, the curve of the island — is laid out at a scale that makes you recalibrate how much ground you've covered since this morning.

The temperature at 2,500m in March will likely be somewhere between 0°C and 8°C, with wind making it feel colder. This is not extreme, but it is sharp — the contrast with the warmth of the city is significant and you will feel it immediately. The layers you brought become essential within about 90 seconds of stepping off the cable car.

The smell arrives next: sulphur, faint but unmistakable, drifting down from the vents above. It is the smell of the earth being actively geological. Your toddler will make a face about it.

On the jeep ride up to 2,900m, the terrain is what most impresses adults on first visit: the lava is not flat. It is buckled, twisted, ropy, and in some places still warm to the touch near fumaroles. The surface looks like a bad special effect — too dramatic to be real, too rugged to be entirely safe-feeling. It is, in fact, quite safe. Walk carefully, watch your footing, hold the toddler's hand when out of the carrier.

At the summit zone, the craters are close enough to be genuinely involving. Steam and gas rise from the vents. The rock around the active vents is stained yellow with sulphur deposits, red with oxidised iron, white with mineral crusts. The colours of the Etna crater zone are extraordinary and appear in almost no photographs with accurate saturation — the camera tends to underexpose the brightness and flatten the colour range. See it with your own eyes.

On a clear day from 2,900m: to the east, the Ionian Sea and the straight of Messina, with Calabria on the Italian mainland visible across the water. To the south, the full length of the Sicilian east coast stretching toward Syracuse. To the west and north, the interior mountains and, on very clear days, the shape of the Aeolian Islands in the sea beyond. The scale of the view is not something that photographs convey. It just isn't.



5.5 The Villages on Etna's Slopes

The volcano is not just a geological event. It is a place where people live — in villages perched on its flanks, farming its extraordinary soil, making wine from vines that grow in volcanic earth at altitude and produce grapes unlike anything else in Italy.

Zafferana Etnea — on the eastern slope, about 600m altitude. This is the honey capital of Etna. The bees work the wildflowers and chestnut blossoms of the mountain and produce a range of honeys that are intensely flavoured and worth buying. The village has a good bar for a coffee and cornetto stop, and an unhurried atmosphere that makes it a pleasant break from the summit experience.

Nicolosi — the main gateway town on the south side, at 700m. The last proper town before the road climbs seriously. Good for a final fuel stop (petrol and breakfast both), with a bar culture that serves Catanesi heading up for the day. Nothing spectacular to see, but a comfortable and real Sicilian mountain town.

Bronte — on the northwestern slope, accessible as a longer excursion or a detour if you approach Etna from the north side. This is the home of the **Pistacchio di Bronte** — the DOP-protected pistachio that appears in everything from pasta to gelato to pastries throughout the region and that, if you've been eating it all week, you now know is one of the great flavours of Sicily. The green of the Bronte pistachio is extraordinary — a deep, saturated, almost jewel-like green that looks artificial and is entirely natural. The harvest is in autumn; in spring, the trees are in flower. Worth a dedicated trip if pistachios have become your thing over the course of this week, which they almost certainly have.

A note on Etna wine: The vineyards on Etna's slopes — particularly on the northern side, around the town of Randazzo — are producing some of the most interesting wine in Italy right now. The volcanic soil, the altitude, and the old vine varieties (Nerello Mascalese for red, Carricante for white) produce wines that are perfumed, mineral, and unlike anything from mainland Italy. **Etna Bianco** in particular is having a global moment — sommeliers in London and New York are extremely excited about it. You can drink it for a fraction of the export price at any enoteca in Catania, and you should. Several Etna wine estates offer tastings; if a winery visit interests you, build it into the Etna day on the way down, when the mountain driving is done and a glass of something local feels exactly right.

Next: Chapter 6 — Day Trip: Taormina

Chapter 6: Day Trip — Taormina

"Taormina is the most beautiful place in the world," wrote Maupassant in 1885. He was exaggerating slightly. But only slightly.

Let's be honest about Taormina before we go any further: it is both extraordinary and extremely touristy. These things coexist. The town has been on every Grand Tour itinerary since the 18th century. It was the preferred retreat of writers, artists, and aristocrats for two centuries. D.H. Lawrence lived here. Truman Capote visited. Marlene Dietrich. The Taormina Film Festival has been running since 1955. The town has been looking good at its own reflection for a very long time and knows it.

In July and August, this means Taormina is genuinely overwhelmed — the narrow streets clogged, the restaurants overpriced, the queue for the Greek theatre stretching back down the hill. In March, it is a different proposition. The cruise ship tourists are not yet in season. The town breathes. You can stand in the Greek theatre with the view to yourself for a moment, and that moment is one of the genuinely remarkable things you will do this week.

Go. Just go early and come back before the afternoon rush.

6.1 Why Taormina is Famous

The town sits at 250 metres on a clifftop spur of Monte Tauro, with the Ionian Sea directly below on one side and the valley — and Etna — on the other. The position alone would be enough to justify the reputation. But Taormina has the Greek theatre as well, and the combination of the ancient theatre with the view is, without much competition, the single most dramatic scenic moment on the Sicilian east coast.

The **Teatro Greco-Romano** was originally built by Greek colonists in the 3rd century BC — it is one of the largest Greek theatres in Sicily, after Syracuse. The Romans, characteristically, modified it substantially: they raised the stage building, changed the orchestra level, and adapted it for

gladiatorial combat and spectacle. What remains is a hybrid that somehow still reads as classical. And the original Greek architects chose the site with an eye for staging that has never been surpassed: the backdrop to the stage is the sea, and behind the sea, on a clear day, Etna.

This was intentional. Greek theatre was a civic and religious act, and the Greeks who sited this theatre understood that placing drama against the scale of the sea and a smoking volcano was itself a dramatic statement. It still works. Two thousand years later, standing in the upper tiers of the seating on a clear March morning, looking at the stage framing the sea and the mountain beyond, it still absolutely works.



6.2 Getting There

From central Catania, the drive north on the **A18 motorway** takes about 50 minutes. The motorway follows the coast — the sea to your right most of the way, the Etna massif building behind you as you leave the city. The drive itself is pleasant, with two or three tunnel sections cut through the coastal headlands. There is a toll; keep coins or a card accessible.

The parking question is the key logistical issue for Taormina.

The town is not accessible by car — or rather, you cannot drive into the town itself without local permits, and even the approach roads are narrow, one-way in sections, and stressful if you don't know them.

The solution is straightforward:

Park at Mazzarò, at the base of the cliff, immediately below Taormina. The car parks here are large, well-signed from the motorway exit, and directly adjacent to the lower cable car station. This is where you park. Always.

From Mazzarò, the **cable car (funivia)** takes you up to the edge of town in a few minutes — small, frequent, cheap, and the views going up give you your first proper sense of Taormina's position. The cable car runs regularly and the queues in March should be short.

One alternative parking option if Mazzarò is full or closed for any reason: **Lumbi car park**, higher on the approach road and accessed from the north side — this puts you closer to town but involves more walking on uneven roads. Mazzarò is the better choice for a family with a pushchair.

From the cable car station at the top, you enter the town via a short walk up through the gardens. The main street — **Corso Umberto** — begins here and runs the length of the town from one end to the other.

6.3 The Must-Sees

The Greek Theatre

Go here first. Immediately. Before the café, before the Corso, before anything else. The theatre opens at 9am (or earlier in some seasons — check in advance) and the early morning, before the tour buses arrive, is the only time you will have it to yourself.

What to do inside: buy your tickets at the entrance, walk through into the theatre, and then do not stop at the lowest level. Walk up the seating tiers — there are steps to either side — until you reach the upper rows. Sit down. Look at the view for at least five minutes before you look at the theatre itself.

The view from the upper tiers is the reason the theatre was built where it was built. The stage arch frames the sea; the sea is framed by the sky; and Etna, on a clear March morning, fills the northern horizon behind and above the whole composition. The scale is such that the ancient architecture and the geology seem to be participating in the same design.

Then look at the theatre itself. The Roman stage building — partially restored, still massive — gives a sense of the spectacle that was staged here. The semicircular seating, cut into the hillside in the Greek manner. The orchestra level. The whole geometry of the space, which directs your eye back to the view at every turn.

Stroller note: the entrance is manageable at ground level. To reach the upper tiers, there are steps. Carry the toddler up; leave the pushchair at the lower level or fold it at the entrance. The extra effort is worth it — the view from the upper tiers is the whole point.

Time to allow: 45 minutes to an hour, if you're being honest. You will stay longer than you plan to.

Villa Comunale (Public Gardens)

At the eastern end of the Corso Umberto, beyond the theatre, the public gardens designed by Lady Florence Trevelyan in the late 19th century offer an entirely different kind of Taormina experience. Lady Trevelyan was English, eccentric, and passionate about botany — she filled the gardens with exotic plants collected from her travels, built several small fantasy pavilions (one of which looks like a birdcage crossed with a Swiss chalet), and created a space that somehow manages to be both genuinely beautiful and mildly ridiculous at the same time.

The gardens have sea views from the eastern edge — on a clear day you can see south toward Catania and north toward the Strait of Messina. There are paths wide enough for a pushchair, benches in the shade, and enough open space for a toddler to run without disappearing over a cliff.

Good for: the nap window, if the timing works. A bench in the shade of the gardens with the sea below is a very good place to sit while the child sleeps in the pram.

Piazza IX Aprile

Midway along the Corso Umberto, Piazza IX Aprile opens to the south as a broad terrace over the valley. This is the view that appears on every Taormina postcard — the coastline stretching south, Etna behind it, the sea below, the town framing it all. There is a café on the square; you should have at least one drink here, on the terrace, looking at this view.

The piazza also has the clock tower (Torre dell'Orologio), which marks the original entrance to the medieval town, and the church of Sant'Agostino (now a library). None of this competes with the view, and none of it needs to.

The Corso Umberto

The main street runs the full length of the town, mostly pedestrianised, and is the central artery of Taormina life. In tourist season it is a gauntlet of souvenir shops, ceramics stalls, linen displays, and restaurant touts. In March it is considerably calmer.

There are genuinely good things among the shops: **Caltagirone ceramics** (the traditional yellow and blue Sicilian style — excellent and packable), quality linen and embroidery, local food products (pistachio cream, Marsala wine, dried herbs). The art is to identify the shops that are selling something real rather than something made in a Chinese factory with a Sicilian flag on the box. Price is usually the guide: if the pistachio cream is suspiciously cheap, it probably contains approximately 8% pistachio.

The best gelato in Taormina is not in the obvious places on the Corso. Ask at a bar for where the locals go. Alternatively: **granita con brioche** at any bar that has queuing Italians rather than tourists — the granita in Taormina is good, the mulberry flavour in season is exceptional.

Stroller note: the Corso itself is paved and manageable. The side streets stepping down from the Corso are often steep stone steps — the town is on a cliff and the terrain is unforgiving of anything with wheels. Keep to the Corso and the theatre for pushchair use; carrier for exploration beyond.

6.4 Eating in Taormina

The honest answer: eating in Taormina costs more than eating in Catania, and the quality does not always justify the premium. The best strategy:

Avoid the restaurants that face directly onto the main piazzas. They are good at marketing themselves and feeding large numbers of tourists efficiently. They are not always good at feeding you well. The restaurants in the streets just behind the Corso — one alley back, slightly harder to find — are where the better food happens.

Lunch rather than dinner. You are driving back to Catania in the afternoon. A good lunch at a table with a view is the right Taormina meal. Dinner in a tourist town at tourist prices is the wrong one.

What to order: fresh grilled fish is the right call. The swordfish (pesce spada) on this part of the coast is excellent. Pasta with clams or mussels. Arancino as a starter if you haven't had one yet today.

If budget is a concern: the town has a small alimentari and a supermarket that are much harder to find than the restaurants. A picnic in the Villa Comunale — bread, local cheese, tomatoes, blood oranges, something sweet — is a legitimate and enjoyable Taormina lunch and costs a fraction of a sit-down meal.

6.5 Honest Notes

The crowds in March are manageable. In May, already beginning to build. July and August: genuinely overcrowded in a way that diminishes the experience significantly. You are going at the right time of year.

The cable car can have queues in peak season. In March, walk-up is usually fine. Check the Funivia Taormina website for the current season schedule before you go, as hours vary.

The weather matters more in Taormina than in the valley. Being on a clifftop at 250m means the wind can be significant even on a warm day — bring a light layer. The view is also much more variable in cloud or mist; a misty day in Taormina is still beautiful but the famous view collapses into grey. In light rain, the town is lovely and far quieter; heavy rain is worth postponing for.

Coming back: leave Taormina by 3:30–4pm to avoid the early evening traffic on the A18 southbound toward Catania. The motorway can be slow around Giarre-Riposto junction; if traffic is visible, the state road along the coast (SS114) is a scenic alternative and runs parallel all the way back.

A historical footnote worth knowing: Taormina in the late 19th and early 20th centuries was one of the first places in Europe where gay men could live relatively openly — the combination of Italian tolerance, distance from northern European social norms, and the bohemian artistic community created an unusual pocket of freedom. The German photographer Wilhelm von Gloeden documented Sicilian youth here in the 1890s in photographs that are still exhibited in the town. The writer and traveller Norman Douglas wrote about Taormina with knowing enthusiasm. The town has always attracted people seeking a life lived differently. It is part of the cultural texture of the place, and worth knowing.

Next: Chapter 7 — Day Trip: Syracuse & Ortigia

Chapter 7: Day Trip — Syracuse & Ortigia

"Syracuse is the greatest of all Greek cities, and the most beautiful of all." — Cicero, 70 BC*

Cicero was not a man given to casual exaggeration, particularly on legal matters, which is essentially what the quote above comes from — he was presenting a legal case about the city's looted art, which required him to establish that Syracuse was worth caring about. He had no difficulty making that argument.

Neither will you.

Syracuse is the day trip that rewards the most preparation and the most time. It is not a quick stop — it is a city that has been continuously inhabited and continuously significant for nearly three thousand years, and the weight of that history is visible in its stones in a way that most ancient sites only hint at. The old town of Ortigia is simultaneously one of the finest baroque centres in Sicily and an island where the streets run on top of Greek city planning from the 5th century BC. The archaeological park on the mainland contains a Greek theatre and a Roman amphitheatre and a cave named by Caravaggio, all within a ten-minute walk of each other.

Give it a full day. Leave early. Come back late.

7.1 Why Syracuse Matters

Founded by Corinthian Greeks in 734 BC, Syracuse grew to become one of the most powerful cities in the ancient Mediterranean world. At its peak, in the 5th and 4th centuries BC, it was larger than Athens. It was one of the great centres of Greek culture, philosophy, and military power.

The Athenians sent their entire naval expeditionary force to capture it in 415–413 BC — the largest amphibious operation in the ancient world up to that point, with 200 ships and 40,000 men. Syracuse defeated them. The Athenian general Nicias was executed. The soldiers were worked to

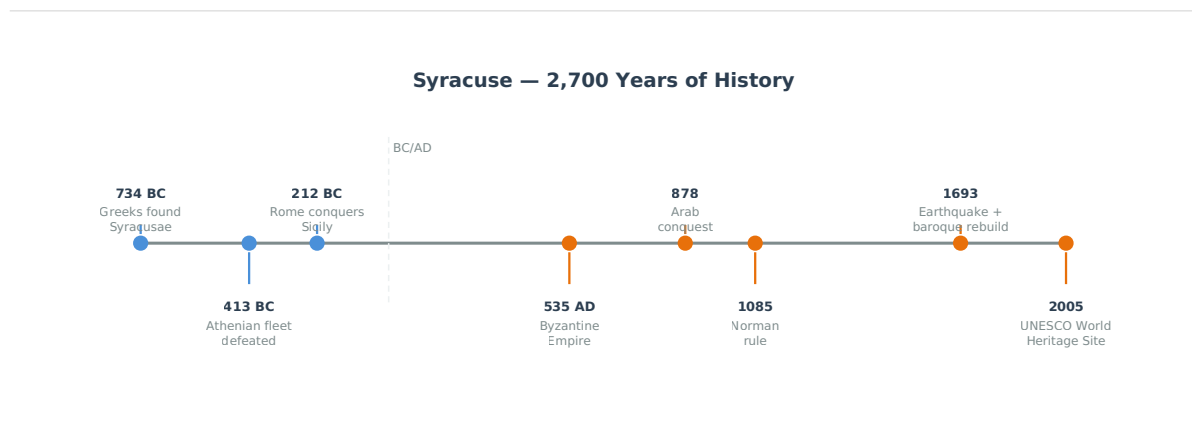
death in the stone quarries outside the city that you will visit this morning. This defeat contributed significantly to Athens' decline and the eventual end of its golden age. That is the scale of what happened here.

Archimedes was born in Syracuse around 287 BC. He spent most of his life here. The screw pump, the principle of water displacement (the bath, the shouting of Eureka), the calculation of pi, the lever principle — all developed here. He was killed by a Roman soldier during the sack of Syracuse in 212 BC, reportedly while working on a mathematical problem. He asked the soldier not to disturb his circles.

Cicero, as we noted, prosecuted Verres for looting the city in 70 BC and described it as the most beautiful city he had seen.

Caravaggio fled to Syracuse in 1608 after killing a man in Rome and spent several months here, producing some of his greatest late works and reportedly naming the cave you'll see this morning.

This is the density of history that Syracuse contains. Not a backdrop, not a ruin to photograph — a place where things happened that changed the world.



7.2 Getting There

From central Catania, take the A18/A19 motorway south. The drive is approximately one hour — straightforward motorway driving along the coast and then inland. The motorway is well-signed for Siracusa.

Parking in the Syracuse area is best managed by splitting the day between the two main sites:

Morning parking for the Neapolis Park: there is a car park at the entrance to the Parco Archeologico della Neapolis on Viale Paradiso. It fills up in high season; in March you should be fine arriving by 9am. From here you walk directly into the archaeological park.

Afternoon in Ortigia: when you move from the park to the island, parking is available on the bridge approach and on the Via Nizza waterfront. Alternatively, the walk from the Neapolis park to Ortigia is about 15 minutes — a perfectly reasonable transition on foot, and it takes you through the modern city centre, which has its own character.

7.3 The Neapolis Archaeological Park

Allow two to three hours here, depending on your pace and the toddler's cooperation. The park is large and open-air; in March the weather is generally kind, and the light on the limestone is beautiful in the morning.

Buy a ticket at the entrance (a combined ticket including the Paolo Orsi Archaeological Museum nearby is usually available and worth considering if you want to add the museum in the afternoon or on a rainy day).

The Greek Theatre

The theatre of Syracuse is one of the finest surviving Greek theatres anywhere in the world. It dates to the 5th century BC in its original form, though it was substantially modified in later centuries. The scale is extraordinary — 138 metres in diameter, with seating cut directly into the limestone hillside of the Temenites hill. In its heyday it held up to 15,000 spectators.

Aeschylus — the father of Greek tragedy — staged world premieres of his plays here at the invitation of the tyrant Hieron I. The Persians may have had its first performance in this theatre. The plays of Sophocles and Euripides were performed here while their authors were alive to see it.

The theatre is still used for performance. The INDA (Istituto Nazionale del Dramma Antico) runs a Greek theatre festival here in alternating years (odd-numbered years), staging Greek and Latin drama in the original space. If your visit happens to coincide with a performance season (typically May–June), tickets for an evening performance are an extraordinary experience.

In March, the theatre is quiet and mostly yours. Sit at the top of the seating bank. Look at the orchestra, the stage, the sky above. Consider that what you are sitting in is not a monument to Greek culture — it is Greek culture, still intact and occasionally still in use.

The Roman Amphitheatre

Immediately adjacent to the Greek theatre, the Roman amphitheatre was built in the 3rd century AD — more than 700 years after the Greek theatre beside it. The proximity of the two structures makes the contrast inescapable: the Greeks cut a theatre for drama and poetry into a hillside; the Romans built an oval arena for blood sport into the earth of the same site. Both are extraordinary. The moral contrast between what each civilisation chose to build for public entertainment is something to turn over in your mind as you walk between them.

The Roman amphitheatre is one of the largest in Italy outside Rome — larger than the arenas at Verona and Capua. It is less complete than the Greek theatre (much of the stone was cannibalised for building material in later centuries), but the scale is still evident, and the underground passage system used to move animals and fighters into the arena is partially accessible and genuinely eerie.

The Ear of Dionysius

This is the one that captures the imagination of everyone who visits, including children.

The **Latomia del Paradiso** — the ancient limestone quarry that supplied the building stone for much of Greek Syracuse — is a dramatic space: a deep trench cut into the rock, open to the sky, with vegetation growing down the walls and an atmosphere of improbable tranquillity given that it was once a quarry and later a prison. The Athenian prisoners captured in the failed 415 BC siege were put to work here. According to Thucydides, the conditions were appalling.

At the back of the quarry, cut into the cliff face, is the ****Ear of Dionysius**** — a tall, narrow artificial cave approximately 65 metres deep, shaped in cross-section like a human ear. The acoustic properties of the cave are extraordinary: a whisper at one end is amplified and audible at the other with startling clarity.

The name was given by **Caravaggio** during his visit to Syracuse in 1608. The legend — enthusiastically promoted then and now — is that the tyrant Dionysius I of Syracuse used the cave as a prison and could hear his prisoners' conversations through the acoustic properties of the rock from a listening point at the top. This is probably not literally true as a historical fact. It is, however, a wonderful story, and the acoustic effect is real and remarkable regardless of origin.

Take the toddler to the far end of the cave and whisper. This is a legitimate use of 2,300 years of architectural history.



The Altar of Hieron

Adjacent to the theatre and quarry, the Altar of Hieron is a long, low platform — essentially all that remains of what was once the largest altar in the ancient world. Hieron II built it in the 3rd century BC to sacrifice to Zeus Eleutherios; the sacrifices conducted here reportedly involved 450 oxen at a time. The altar stretched 198 metres in length.

What you see today is the base — the stone superstructure was demolished in the Spanish period and the material reused. The sheer length of the platform, however, conveys the ambition of the original: nearly 200 metres of carved limestone, longer than the Parthenon is wide. Worth the short walk for a moment of scale.

Stroller note: The Neapolis park has a mix of paved paths and gravel surfaces. The main routes between the theatre, the amphitheatre, and the quarry are manageable with a pushchair with care. The Ear of Dionysius cave itself is flat-floored and accessible, though you may want to fold the pushchair at the entrance to navigate the narrow interior. A carrier gives more flexibility throughout.

7.4 Ortigia — The Island Old Town

Cross to Ortigia by car (10-minute drive) or on foot (15–20 minutes). The island is connected to the mainland by two short bridges; you will know you've arrived when the streets narrow and the stone changes from modern concrete to baroque pale limestone.

Ortigia is a small island — roughly 600 metres by 1,000 metres — but it has been continuously occupied since at least the 8th century BC and contains more layers of history per square metre than almost anywhere else in Sicily. The street plan still loosely follows Greek city planning. The buildings are largely baroque, rebuilt after the 1693 earthquake. The substrate below is Greek, Roman, Byzantine, Arab, and Norman, in rough sequence.

The Cathedral of Syracuse

The cathedral stands on the highest point of the island, on the site of the most important Greek temple in Syracuse — the **Temple of Athena**, built in the 5th century BC after the Syracusan victory over the Carthaginians at the Battle of Himera.

The temple was converted to a Christian church in the 7th century AD. The nave of the cathedral is the interior of the temple. The outer walls of the cathedral incorporate the original **Doric columns** of the temple,

still standing in their original positions, still load-bearing, now embedded in the baroque masonry. You can see them from the street on the north side of the building — a row of fluted limestone columns, 5th century BC, doing what they have been doing for 2,500 years.

Inside, the cathedral reads as an extraordinarily layered space: Greek columns forming the side aisles, Byzantine mosaics partially preserved in the nave (mostly covered by later decoration), Norman remains, baroque chapels added in the post-1693 reconstruction. The whole building is a compressed history of Western civilisation arranged in three dimensions.

This is free to enter. Go inside. Stand in the nave and look up at the ceiling, then look sideways at the columns, then look back at the main altar. Every surface is doing something different from a different century.



The Fountain of Arethusa

At the southern tip of the island, where the land ends at the edge of the harbour, a freshwater spring bubbles up from the rock. This is the **Fonte Aretusa** — a spring that has been running since antiquity, surrounded by papyrus plants (an Egyptian reed plant growing here in the Mediterranean — already strange), and facing the open sea.

In Greek mythology, Arethusa was a nymph and huntress who attracted the attention of the river god Alpheus. To escape him, she was transformed into an underground river by the goddess Artemis and traveled beneath the sea from Greece to Sicily, emerging here as a freshwater spring. Alpheus followed her and his waters mingle with hers in the spring. The papyrus plants are thought to have grown here since the time of the ancient contact between Syracuse and Egypt.

The spring is real. The papyrus is real. The geographical impossibility of freshwater emerging at the edge of the sea is real. The myth is one of the great Greek explanatory stories — taking something genuinely mysterious and giving it a narrative that is more satisfying than geology.

Sit at the fountain for a few minutes. The ducks that live here will investigate your toddler. The sea is immediately below the wall. On the far side of the harbour, the ancient city of Syracuse spreads out. This is a place where the mythological and the actual are, unusually, occupying exactly the same ground.

The Ortigia Covered Market (Via Trento)

Morning only — if you arrive before noon. A small, atmospheric market selling fresh fish, vegetables, and local produce. The size and intensity of La Pescheria in Catania this is not — the Ortigia market is compact and quieter — but the quality is high and the setting, in a vaulted space just off the main square, is characterful.

Good for: a mid-morning snack before lunch (the street food here is good — pane e panelle if available, or fresh arancino), and buying local capers, dried tomatoes, or Sicilian spices to take home.

The Ortigia Waterfront

The **Lungomare** (waterfront promenade) runs along the eastern edge of the island, facing the open sea. In the afternoon and evening, this is where the aperitivo culture of Syracuse concentrates: bars with outdoor seating, the light changing over the water, the boats in the small harbours.

Aperitivo here is the right way to end the Ortigia afternoon — a glass of something local (Nero d'Avola, or a local spumante), a small plate of olives and caponata, the sea in front of you and the baroque facade of Ortigia behind. This is the moment that the day has been building toward.

Ortigia island waterfront, Syracuse

7.5 Eating in Syracuse

The Ortigia market (morning) for street food.

Lunch in Ortigia: look for restaurants in the streets between Via Maestranza and the cathedral — the lanes running inland from the main waterfront have better value and better food than the obvious restaurant strip along the lungomare. Ask for the catch of the day; this close to the sea, in a fishing town, fresh fish is what you should be eating.

Arancino in Syracuse: the Syracuse arancino is notably different from Catania's — round rather than conical, and the fillings can vary more. Worth trying both during the course of the week and forming an opinion. People in Catania and Syracuse have very strong opinions about whose is better. You are allowed to have your own.

Budget note: Syracuse is somewhat less expensive than Taormina for eating and slightly more than Catania. A good lunch in Ortigia for two adults and a toddler, with drinks, should be in the €35–50 range in a mid-level restaurant — more if you order greedily, less if you use the market for part of the meal.

The Paolo Orsi Archaeological Museum — adjacent to the Neapolis park, about 500m from the theatre entrance — is one of the most important archaeological museums in Europe and is entirely worth the visit, especially as a rainy-day alternative to the open-air park.

The collections cover prehistoric Sicily, the Greek colonisation, the Roman period, and the subsequent civilisations, all with exceptional quality of presentation. If you are going to see one museum on this trip, this is the one. The toddler verdict: the Greek and Roman sections have enough large dramatic objects (entire sculptural groups, impressive ceramics, armour) to hold the attention for at least an hour. Allow 2 hours for a proper visit.

Next: Chapter 8 — Day Trip: The Coast

Chapter 8: Day Trip — The Coast

"I faraglioni? Quelli li ha buttati il Ciclope."

"Those sea stacks? The Cyclops threw them."

— Every person in Aci Trezza, forever

After the cultural intensity of Syracuse and the altitude drama of Etna, the coast day exists as a corrective. It is the easiest, most restorative day of the week. The plan is: drive 20 minutes, eat fish, look at mythological sea stacks, let the toddler run at the water's edge, eat gelato, drive back. That is the entire agenda. There is no subtext.

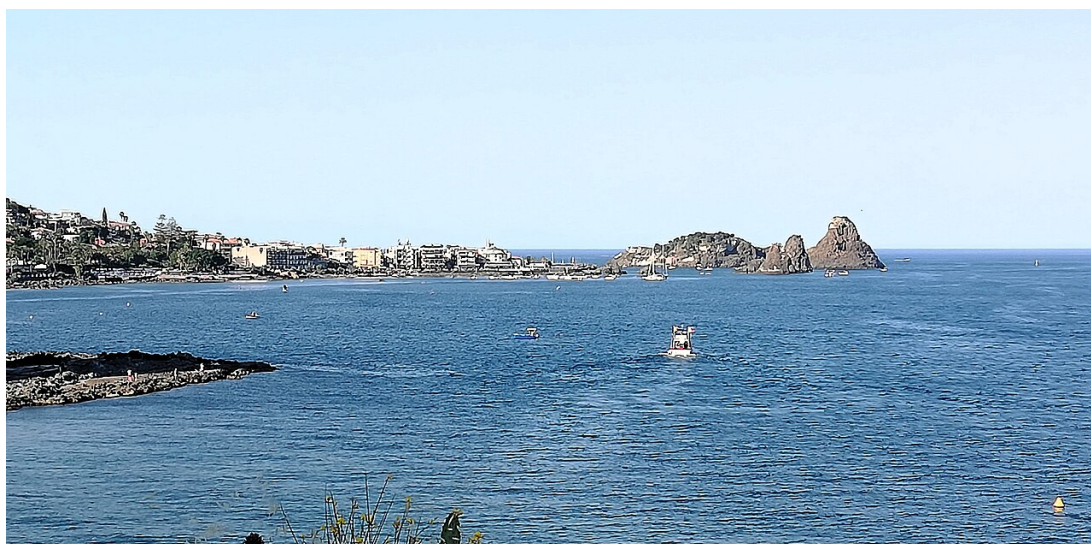
The Riviera dei Ciclopi — the Cyclops Riviera — is the stretch of coastline immediately north of Catania, named for the legend that the extraordinary black basalt sea stacks off Aci Trezza are the rocks that the blinded Cyclops Polyphemus hurled at Odysseus. It is one of the more dramatically named coastlines in the Mediterranean, and it earns it: the sea stacks are genuinely extraordinary, rising straight out of turquoise water in columns that look hand-placed rather than geological. They are not, in fact, hand-placed by a giant. They are lava intrusions from an ancient eruption, harder than the surrounding rock and thus left standing when everything around them eroded. But the Cyclops story is better, and the coastal residents of Aci Trezza have been telling it for at least 2,700 years.

8.1 The Myth

Book IX of Homer's *Odyssey*. Odysseus and his men, on the way home from Troy, make landfall near a cave they don't immediately recognise as the home of a Cyclops. They go inside. The Cyclops — Polyphemus — comes home with his sheep, rolls a boulder across the entrance, and eats two of Odysseus's men. Odysseus gets him drunk on wine, blinds him with a sharpened stake while he sleeps, escapes from the cave hidden under the bellies of the sheep, and puts to sea.

Polyphemus, blind and enraged, hears Odysseus taunting him from the boats and hurls the tops of mountains at the sound of his voice. Two of them land near the ships. The sea stacks visible from the harbour of Aci Trezza today are, in the story, those rocks. The largest — the **Isola Lachea** — became over time an actual island, inhabited, farmed, and now a protected marine reserve.

What is interesting about this, beyond the beauty of the myth, is that the Homeric tradition was clearly mapping real geography. The rocks exist. The coastline exists. Someone, at some point in the Greek literary tradition, looked at these black basalt sea stacks rising out of the sea north of Syracuse and thought: that is where the Cyclops threw the rocks. Once you see the rocks in person, you understand immediately why the story attached to them and not somewhere else.



8.2 Aci Trezza

Aci Trezza is a small fishing village about 15 kilometres north of Catania — a 20-minute drive from the historic centre, depending on traffic through the northern suburbs. It is not a resort and not a tourist town in any meaningful sense. It has a working harbour, a seafront, a handful of excellent seafood restaurants, and the rocks.

The harbour area is the social centre of the village: fishing boats come in and out in the morning, the catch is sold on the quay, and the bars along the waterfront open early and stay open late. The atmosphere is entirely local — Catanesi come here for Sunday lunch, not tourists on a package holiday.

*Giovanni Verga's novel *I Malavoglia**** — published in 1881 and one of the great works of Italian verismo fiction — is set in Aci Trezza. The novel follows a fishing family's decline over a generation, and the village, the harbour, the culture of hard work and hard luck that Verga documents, is all recognisable in the Aci Trezza of today. If you've read it, the village will feel eerily familiar. If you haven't, the knowledge that this place was significant enough to anchor one of the major novels of the Italian literary tradition gives it a weight that the unprepared tourist misses.

The sea stacks — the **Faraglioni di Aci Trezza** — are visible from the harbour. The main group includes the **Scoglio Grande**, the ****Scoglio di Mezzo**, **and the** Faraglione piccolo, **plus the** Isola Lachea** further out (the natural reserve, not reachable without a permit). Boat trips run from the harbour to circle the rocks — 30 to 45 minutes, cheap, and well worth doing if the sea is calm enough. The view from the water between the columns is extraordinary and impossible to replicate from shore.

For the toddler: the waterfront promenade is flat and pram-friendly. The water access is primarily from lava rock platforms rather than a sandy beach — not ideal for sand-based toddler entertainment, but perfectly good for paddling if the child is interested in scrambling. The boat trip is a genuine hit with small children — moving boat, large rocks, seabirds — and the duration is short enough to be manageable.

8.3 Aci Castello

Aci Castello is a short drive south from Aci Trezza (or a 20-minute walk along the coast road), and it has the most dramatically positioned Norman castle on the whole east coast.

The **Castello di Aci** was built in the 11th century by the Normans on a platform of black basalt rock that juts into the sea at the edge of the village. The rock is a basalt intrusion — the same geological phenomenon as the sea stacks, just attached to the land rather than surrounded by water. The castle sits on this platform maybe 10 metres above the sea,

connected to the shore by a short bridge and a ramp. From any angle, the image is the same: a medieval castle balanced on black volcanic rock over the blue Ionian Sea.

The castle houses a small **Civic Museum** with local geological and archaeological finds — fossils from the lava rock, Greek and Roman pottery from the area, some medieval artefacts. The museum is modest and honest about being modest; the castle exterior and the view from the platform over the sea are the reason to come.

Climb the castle if the toddler's energy allows it — the ramparts offer a view north toward the Faraglioni, south toward Catania (the city visible as a smudge on the coast), and directly down into the extraordinarily clear water below. In calm conditions, the water off the castle rock is transparent to several metres depth, and the colours — turquoise, blue, green over the dark basalt — are vivid in a way that photographs rarely capture accurately.

The village below the castle has a good gelato shop and a couple of bars facing the sea. A coffee or granita here, looking at the castle from below, with the sea behind it, is a very good use of 20 minutes.



8.4 Beaches on This Coast

A note of honesty: the coastline immediately around Aci Trezza and Aci Castello is primarily rock and lava platform, not sand. It is beautiful. It is dramatic. It is genuinely good for paddling and rockpool exploration. It is not the wide sandy beach of a Mediterranean postcard.

If you want sand — and a toddler who wants to dig deserves sand — the options are:

Lido di Plaia (south of Catania, near the airport):

The main city beach of Catania — long, flat, sandy, with sun lounger and umbrella hire in the lido sections and free public beach (spiaggia libera) in between. The beach runs for several kilometres and can absorb a lot of people; in March it will be very quiet. Not the most spectacular coastline you will see on this trip, but honest and accessible and genuinely sandy. 15 minutes by car from the historic centre — this is a viable option even for a half-day, and particularly good if the more ambitious day trips get weathered out.

Fondachello / Mascalì (north of Aci Trezza, toward Giarre):

A quieter section of coast, volcanic black sand, less commercial, more local. The beach is not long, but the atmosphere is relaxed and the sand exists. Good option if you want coast without the lido structure.

The rocks at Aci Trezza and Aci Castello (already described):

Excellent for everything except sand-based entertainment. For a toddler who is happy in rockpools and with water access, this is more interesting than a flat sandy beach.

In March: water temperature is around 14°C — cold enough that swimming is for the brave. Paddling is fine; swimming is a choice. The weather may be warm enough to sit on the rocks in the sun comfortably. Do not promise anyone a beach holiday in March and then be surprised by the sea temperature.

The Cyclopean Coast — What to Do Where



Drive north along the SP59 coastal road · no motorway needed · Aci Trezza and Aci Castello are 10 min apart

8.5 Eating on the Coast

This is, without competition, the easiest eating decision of the week. You are on a coast with fishing boats. Order fish. The fish was in the water this morning. Order the grilled swordfish, or the pasta with clams, or whatever the waiter suggests when you ask what is freshest. Do not order the pasta with meat. You are on the Cyclops coast in Sicily. Order the fish.

Best area for lunch: the waterfront restaurants in Aci Trezza, facing the harbour. They are unpretentious, the tables are often outside with sea views, and the pricing is honest — this is a local eating area, not a tourist destination with tourist pricing.

What to drink with it: the house white will be a local Sicilian white — probably not Etna Bianco, but something from the DOC Sicilia range that will be cold, clean, and entirely correct with grilled fish. Order a litre carafe rather than a bottle if you want something simple and good without a decision.

For the toddler: pasta with butter or tomato sauce (al pomodoro) is available everywhere and is exactly as good as it sounds when made with good pasta and good tomatoes. Blood orange juice if they have it. Fresh bread while you wait, which will arrive without asking because Sicily.

Budget context: lunch on the coast for two adults and a toddler, with drinks, should be €30–40 in a mid-range waterfront trattoria in Aci Trezza. Substantially cheaper than Taormina; comparable to a good lunch in Catania.

8.6 Acireale: The Rainy Coast Alternative

If the coast day is too wet for the rocks and the beach, **Acireale** — 10 minutes north of Aci Trezza on the SS114 coast road — is one of the better-kept secrets of the Catania hinterland. It is a small baroque city at 160m altitude on the slopes above the coast, largely ignored by tourists and entirely worth an hour or two.

The historic centre has a cathedral, a fine baroque piazza (**Piazza del Duomo), **and the extraordinary** Basilica dei Santi Pietro e Paolo** with its peculiar twin spires that are visible for miles along the coast. There are good pastry shops and bars in the centre. In late January and February, Acireale hosts the most elaborate Carnival celebrations in all of Sicily — papier-mâché floats of extraordinary size and craft. In March, a week after Carnival, the town is quiet and the pasticcerie are still stocked.

In the rain: the covered market near the centro, a coffee in one of the old bars on the piazza, a walk to the belvedere that looks back down over the coast. An easy half-day, very local, costs nothing.

A final thought on the coast day: it is tempting to try to pack more into it — to drive further north to Taormina while you're already going that direction, or to add Acireale and Aci Trezza and the beach all in one go. Resist this instinct. The coast day works precisely because it is not packed. The value is in sitting on a harbour wall looking at mythological sea stacks and eating fresh fish without anywhere to be afterward. That is the whole point. Let it be enough.

Next: Chapter 9 — Eat Your Way Through Catania

Chapter 9: Eat Your Way Through Catania

"In Sicily, eating is not a biological necessity. It is a cultural position. A declaration of values. A form of argument."

There is a reason this chapter comes after all the day trips and before the practical tips. Food is not a footnote to your time in Catania — it is woven through everything you do, every morning, every afternoon, every evening. The granita you had on the first day. The fish you watched being sold at La Pescheria at 8am and then ate for lunch an hour later. The arancino you ate standing up in the street because there was nowhere to sit and no time to wait.

All of that is this chapter. So is the history behind it — because to eat well in Sicily, it helps to understand why Sicilian food tastes the way it does, and the answer to that question is twelve centuries of Arab, Norman, Greek, Spanish, and Italian history all ending up in a single dish.

9.1 The Arab Kitchen — Sicily's Secret Ingredient

Here is the thing most people don't know about Sicilian food: it is profoundly, structurally Arab.

Between the 9th and 11th centuries, Arab and Berber forces from North Africa controlled most of Sicily and transformed its agriculture, its irrigation, and its diet more thoroughly than any conqueror before or after. They introduced sugar cane — and with it the concept of confectionery that defines Sicilian pastry culture today. They introduced rice — and with it, eventually, arancino. They introduced aubergine, which became the central ingredient of two of Sicily's defining dishes (caponata and pasta alla Norma). They introduced almonds, pine nuts, raisins, saffron, cinnamon, and cumin — the spice vocabulary that makes Sicilian cooking unlike any other regional Italian cuisine and immediately recognisable once you know what you're tasting.

The Arab sweet-sour flavour combination — agrodolce — runs through Sicilian cooking as a structural principle. Sweet elements (raisins, honey, sugar) and sour elements (vinegar, citrus) appear together in both savoury and sweet dishes

in combinations that would be unusual in northern Italian cooking and that trace directly back to the medieval Arab kitchen. Caponata: sweet-sour. Sarde a beccafico: sweet-sour. The flavour of a good Sicilian aubergine dish: sweet-sour.

This is not ancient history. It is what your food tastes like. Every time you eat something in Catania this week, you are eating a culinary tradition that absorbed Arab, Greek, Norman, and Spanish influences over a thousand years and emerged as something entirely its own.

9.2 The Essential Catanian Foods

What follows is not a comprehensive list of Sicilian food — that would be a book in itself, and a long one. This is the list of things you should specifically eat in Catania, ideally in the way described, ideally in the order that your schedule and appetite allow.

Granita con Brioche — The Sicilian Morning

You have already had this. You will have it again. You should have it every morning if that is what you want, because it is exactly that kind of thing.

A Sicilian granita is not a smoothie, not a slushie, not a snow cone. It is a semi-frozen preparation made from water, sugar, and a real flavouring ingredient — almonds, pistachios, coffee, citrus, fresh berries, mulberry, jasmine — that is agitated as it freezes to produce a fine, icy, intensely flavoured texture that is somewhere between sorbet and crushed ice and neither. It is served in a glass, often with a small portion of panna (whipped cream) on top, alongside a **brioche** — a soft, slightly sweet bread roll made with lard that is the Sicilian version, distinct from the French brioche.

You eat the brioche with the granita. You break off a piece and use it to scoop. Or — the Catanian version — you split the brioche open and fill it with the granita directly, eating it like an ice cream sandwich. This is breakfast. Not a dessert, not a treat — breakfast. The bar culture around this is completely normalised; ordering a granita at 7:30am alongside your espresso raises no eyebrows.

The best flavours: almond (mandorla) is the most traditional and the most Sicilian — made from ground almonds and almond milk, intensely flavoured, completely different from anything you'll have had before. Pistachio

(pistacchio) is rich and extraordinary, especially if made with Bronte pistachios. Coffee (caffè) is the purist's choice. Lemon (limone) is sharp and clean. Mulberry (gelsi) in season (late spring/summer) is exceptional.

Where to get it: any good bar or pasticceria in Catania. The rule of thumb: if the granita is made on site (not from a commercial preparation), it will be better. Ask if it is artigianale (artisan-made). The price is low everywhere — this is not a premium product.

Arancino — Catania's Own

The arancino (Catanian) or arancina (Palermitan) debate is the most actively contested food argument in Sicily, and it is about both the name and the shape.

In Catania, it is **arancino** (masculine), it is **conical** — shaped like a small version of Etna, a point that Catanesi make with complete seriousness — and the standard filling is a ragù of meat, tomato, and peas. In Palermo, it is **arancina** (feminine), it is round, and the culture around it is different in ways that Palermitans will explain at length if given the opportunity.

In both cases: a ball of cooked and seasoned risotto rice, shaped around a filling, breaded, and deep fried until the exterior is golden and crunchy and the interior is hot and soft and yielding. When done well — and in Catania, it is done well frequently — it is one of the great street food experiences anywhere.

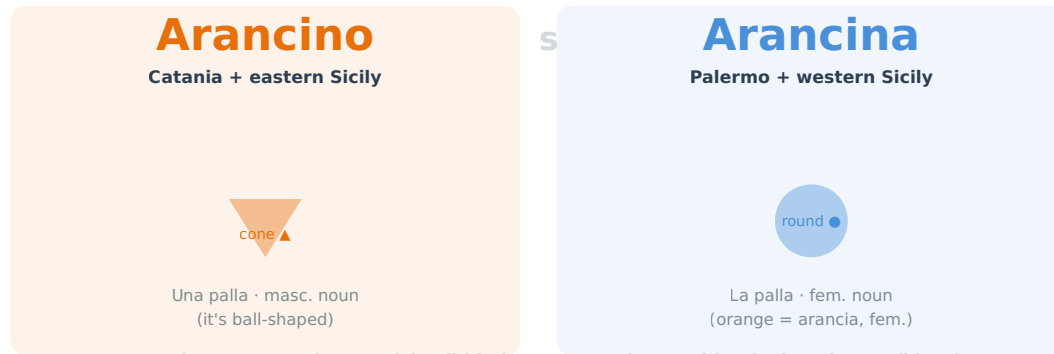
The fillings: the classic ragù (meat, tomato, peas) is the baseline. Butter and mozzarella (al burro) is the alternative — simpler, excellent. Modern variants include spinach and ricotta, pistachio and sausage, and whatever the creative arancino-maker of the day has decided to try. The classic ragù is the right first order.

When to eat it: technically any time of day, but arancino is quintessentially a morning or midday food in Catania — eaten standing up at a bar, wrapped in paper, before or during the morning market. It is not a dinner. It is not a sit-down restaurant item. It is street food, and it should be eaten as such.

Where to get it: the bars around La Pescheria are the traditional morning arancino territory. Find the place with a queue of people in work clothes.

Arancino vs Arancina — The Great Sicilian Debate

Both are the same thing: a fried rice ball filled with ragù or cheese. The name is the war.



In Catania: say "arancino" or risk mild judgement. Both taste identical. Order confidently.

A fun illustrated spread: on the left, the Catanian arancino — conical shape, labelled with the Etna comparison, masculine article, "al ragù" filling. On the right, the Palermitan arancina — round shape, feminine article, different filling tradition. A map of Sicily showing the approximate boundary between the two naming traditions. Tone: playful, partisan (this guide is from Catania), clearly not taking itself too seriously.

Pasta alla Norma — The City's Own Pasta

This is Catania's contribution to the canon of Italian pasta dishes, and it was invented here, and it is named after an opera, and this is entirely normal for a city that produced Vincenzo Bellini.

Bellini — whose opera *Norma* premiered in Milan in 1831 and immediately entered the repertoire of great works — was born in Catania in 1801. His birthplace, on Piazza San Francesco, is now a museum. His monument stands in the public gardens. The Teatro Massimo Bellini — the city's main opera house, inaugurated in 1890 — is named after him. And, most deliciously, when a local chef created a pasta dish so good that a fellow Catanian exclaimed *"è una Norma!"* — meaning it was as magnificent as Bellini's opera — the dish kept the name.

The dish: rigatoni (or sometimes spaghetti) with a fresh tomato sauce, deep-fried slices of aubergine, a grating of ricotta salata (a firm, salty, dry ricotta quite different from the fresh version), and fresh basil. It is simple, summer-focused, and completely dependent on the quality of its ingredients — which in Catania in the tomato and aubergine season is exceptional. In March, it is slightly off-peak seasonally, but still very good.

If someone tells you something is una Norma in Catania, they mean it's the best thing they've had in a while. Cook this dish when you get home and tell people the story. They will be impressed.

Sarde a Beccafico — The Arab-Norman Palimpsest on a Plate

This dish is a direct taste of the Arab-Norman fusion that defines so much of Sicilian cooking. Fresh sardines, butterflied and filled with a mixture of breadcrumbs, pine nuts, raisins, and sometimes orange zest, then rolled, packed tightly in a baking dish, and baked. The sweet (raisins, orange) and savoury (sardines, breadcrumbs) combination is precisely the agrodolce principle at work — and the ingredients trace directly to the Arab pantry of 9th-century Sicily.

The name refers to the **beccafico** — a small migratory bird that in autumn grows fat on figs and was considered a delicacy by the Sicilian aristocracy. The rolled sardines, tails pointing upward, are said to resemble the little birds. This is the kind of culinary metaphor that tells you something about the culture that created it: a dish invented to let ordinary people eat something that looks like an aristocratic delicacy, named with a knowing wink.

It is not universally available in Catania's restaurants — more common in Palermo, where it is a staple — but when you see it, order it.

Caponata — Sicily in a Bowl

A sweet-sour aubergine stew that appears everywhere in Sicily as an antipasto, a side dish, or a meal in itself. The core ingredients are aubergine (fried separately and then combined), tomato, celery, olives, capers, vinegar, and sugar. The balance between the sweet and the sour is the cook's art, and it varies significantly from kitchen to kitchen.

Caponata is served at room temperature, which is correct and intentional — it is not a hot dish. It improves with sitting. The best version you eat this week will probably be one you have for lunch as an antipasto when the kitchen made it that morning or the night before.

Take some home if you can: good-quality jarred caponata is sold in the markets and in good food shops throughout Catania, and it is one of the more transportable and authentic things to bring back.

Street Food at La Pescheria

The market experience includes eating. This is not optional.

Along the edges of La Pescheria, especially at the street-facing end near the arch on Via Garibaldi, vendors sell prepared seafood for immediate consumption.

The main things to try:

Polipo bollito — boiled octopus, served whole (for a small octopus) or in chunks, with lemon and salt. Eaten standing up with a toothpick from a paper cup. Extraordinarily fresh. A specific kind of delicious that only works when the octopus was in the water the previous day.

Ricci di mare — sea urchin, split open in front of you, the orange interior scraped out and spread onto a piece of bread. Sea urchin has a flavour that is described inadequately as "intensely oceanic" — it is the concentrated essence of the sea. You either become immediately addicted or you do not. There is almost no middle ground.

Cazzilli — small fried potato croquettes, simple, addictive, sold from carts near the market and throughout the street food scene of Catania.

Fried things in paper cones — various small seafood items, battered and fried, sold by weight. Order a mixed portion and eat it walking.

None of this costs much. All of it is better eaten at 8am, leaning against the market wall, with a coffee from the nearest bar as counterpoint.

Cannoli — The One You Came For

Let us address the cannolo directly, because there are cannoli and there are cannoli, and the difference matters.

The shell should be thin and crisp, made from fried pastry dough, and it should shatter when you bite into it. If it does not shatter, the shell has been sitting too long and the filling has softened it. This is not a good cannolo.

The filling is fresh sheep's milk ricotta, sweetened, sometimes flavoured with vanilla or a little cinnamon, studded with chocolate chips or candied orange peel or pistachio. The ricotta should taste of sheep's milk — fresh, slightly grassy, creamy. If it tastes of nothing in particular, it is not fresh sheep's milk ricotta.

The crucial rule: the cannolo should be filled in front of you, to order. A cannolo that was filled in advance, sitting in a display case for hours, is a version of a cannolo that you should decline politely and move on. The shell will have absorbed moisture from the ricotta and lost its structural integrity. The flavour combination that makes a cannolo extraordinary requires the contrast between the crisp shell and the soft filling to be intact. This only happens if you eat it within minutes of filling.

The best cannoli in Catania are served at the pasticcerie that make the shells and the ricotta themselves. Ask locals; the recommendations will be specific and vehement.

For the toddler: yes. Obviously yes.

Minnuzzi di Sant'Agata — The Pastry With a Story

Available in every pasticceria in Catania, particularly in and around the festival period in February: small white confections made from marzipan or a ricotta-based filling, shaped and iced to represent the breasts of Sant'Agata. The saint was martyred by having her breasts cut off, and Catanesi have been making pastries in her honour in this specific shape since at least the medieval period.

This is — to understate considerably — an unusual confection. It is also very good. The marzipan version is almond-flavoured and dense; the ricotta version is lighter and slightly sweeter. They are sold year-round and are one of the more distinctively Catanian things you can buy or eat here. The story behind them is worth knowing, and worth telling to anyone who asks why your souvenir box of pastries looks the way it does.

The Blood Orange — Not a Metaphor, Actually a Blood Orange

The **Arancia Rossa di Sicilia** — the blood orange of Sicily — is a DOP (Protected Designation of Origin) product grown in the volcanic soil of the Etna foothills and the Catania plain. Three varieties: Moro (deepest red, most pigmented, slightly berry-forward), Tarocco (the sweetest, most complex, the one most Sicilians consider the finest), and Sanguinello (darker and more tannic). The red pigmentation comes from anthocyanins that develop in response to cold night temperatures — the same volcanic soil and diurnal temperature variation that makes Etna wine distinctive is what makes the blood orange extraordinary.

These are not the blood oranges you buy in the supermarket at home. The ones grown here taste different: more complex, with a berry note layered over the citrus that makes them unlike any other orange. The season is roughly November to May — you are going at the right time.

Buy them at the market by the kilo. They are extraordinarily cheap. Eat them as fruit; drink the juice squeezed fresh (*spremuta*) at any bar; take a bag home if your luggage allows it.

9.3 Where and How to Eat

The Structure of a Sicilian Meal

A proper Sicilian restaurant meal works in this sequence:

Antipasto — the starter. Often the best course. In Catania: caponata, bruschetta, seafood selections, arancino, local cheeses, cured meats. Order more than you think you need.

Primo — the pasta or risotto course. This is not a starter in the Anglo-Saxon sense — it is a full course. Pasta alla Norma, pasta with clams (*alle vongole*), pasta with sea urchin (*ai ricci*) if you're feeling ambitious, pasta al nero di seppia (with cuttlefish ink, dramatic-looking, excellent-tasting).

Secondo — the main course. Fish is the right call in Catania: grilled swordfish (*pesce spada alla griglia*), grilled tuna (*tonno*), baked sea bream (*orata*). Meat is also available; the Sicilian mixed grill is good. Vegetables served separately as *contorni* — order the grilled aubergine and the fried courgettes.

Dolce — dessert. Cannolo, obviously. Cassata siciliana (if you're in the mood for something baroque in structure as well as origin — a ricotta and marzipan cake with candied fruit). Gelato. Or, if you have been eating for two hours, a small almond pastry and another coffee.

You do not have to eat all of this at every meal. In practice, a lunch might be antipasto + primo, or just a good secondo with bread. The full four-course structure is for evenings and celebrations. But knowing it means you will not be confused when the menu lists five different sections and the waiter expects you to navigate them.

Timings — The Most Important Practical Note

Sicilian meal times are not Italian meal times, which are already late by northern European standards. They are later.

Breakfast: 7–10am, at a bar, standing or at a small table.

Lunch: 1pm–3pm. Restaurants will not seat you for lunch at noon; they will be setting up. The earliest realistic sit-down lunch is 12:45pm.

Dinner: no earlier than 8pm. Many restaurants don't fill until 9pm. The full Sicilian dinner culture moves late in a way that is difficult to reconcile with a toddler who needs to be in bed by 8:30pm.

The family solution: eat your main meal at lunch, when the food is the same quality, the pace is slightly faster, and the prices are occasionally lower. Use dinner as a lighter, earlier affair — a *tavola calda* (hot food counter), a pizza, something simple at 7:30pm before the local restaurants have warmed up. Nobody will think less of you for this.

Types of Places to Eat — The Hierarchy

Ristorante: full service, full menu, full prices. The place for a special occasion meal.

Trattoria: simpler, often family-run, shorter menu focused on local cooking. The correct choice for a good lunch at honest prices. Usually no printed menu or a very short one — the waiter will tell you what's available.

Osteria: even simpler, often wine-focused, sometimes no kitchen or very limited food. For drinking, primarily.

Tavola calda: literally "hot table" — a canteen-style place with prepared food on display and counter service. Extremely good value, completely unpretentious, often excellent. The closest Sicilian equivalent to a good deli lunch. Very toddler-friendly.

Bar/Pasticceria: for breakfast, granita, coffee, pastries, a quick arancino. Not for lunch or dinner, but the most important category for the first two hours of every day.

Street food vendors: at markets, in the streets near the fish market, at certain fixed positions around the city centre. The cheapest eating in Catania and, often, the most memorable.



Catania Food Map

Key locations: La Pescheria · Via Plebiscito · Piazza Carlo Alberto

openstreetmap.org → search "Catania historic centre"

9.4 Drinking in Catania

Coffee

Sicily takes coffee seriously in the Neapolitan tradition — espresso, short, strong, consumed quickly at the bar counter. The Sicilian variation: coffee granita for breakfast, as described above, or caffè d'orzo (barley coffee) as an alternative if you want something lighter. Ordering a "latte" in a Sicilian bar will get you a glass of warm milk. Order cappuccino until 11am; after that, only tourists order milky coffee, and you will be identified as one.

Wine

Sicily is a serious wine region with a rapidly evolving reputation, and the wines available in Catania for local prices represent extraordinary value. The main categories to know:

Etna Rosso — made from Nerello Mascalese grapes grown at altitude on the volcanic slopes of Etna. Elegant, perfumed, with a lightness of body that can surprise people expecting a big Sicilian red. The comparison often made by wine critics is to Burgundy — not in flavour, but in the relationship between the wine, the specific volcanic soil (terroir), and the altitude. Several small producers are now internationally famous and exported at prices that would make your eyes water in London or New York. In Catania you can drink them for €15–25 a bottle. Do.

Etna Bianco — made from Carricante and other local white varieties. Mineral, saline, with a freshness and complexity that makes it one of the most interesting Italian whites of the moment. The right wine with the grilled fish at Aci Trezza. The right wine with the seafood pasta in Ortigia. The right wine in general, throughout the week.

Nero d'Avola — the great red grape of southern Sicily, grown widely across the island. Rich, dark, full-bodied, with a flavour of black cherries and dark spice. Not an Etna wine, but a Sicilian classic. Good with the meat-based pasta dishes and the secondo of grilled meat.

Malvasia delle Lipari — technically from the Aeolian Islands, but available throughout Sicily. A sweet, amber-coloured dessert wine with extraordinary concentration and a honeyed, apricot character. Order it with a cannolo or at the end of the meal instead of dessert.

Blood Orange Juice

Already covered in the food section, but worth repeating in the drinks context: spremuta di arancia rossa — freshly squeezed blood orange juice — is available at every bar that has a juicer and is the single best non-alcoholic drink of the trip. Order it for the toddler every morning. Order it for yourself every morning. It is a different product from orange juice as you know it.

Next: Chapter 10 — Family Field Guide

Chapter 10: Family Field Guide

"The best thing about travelling in Sicily with a small child is that Sicilians think a small child is the best thing about anything."

Everything in this chapter has been mentioned in context throughout the guide. This is where it all comes together in one place — the consolidated practical reference for the reality of a week in Catania with a toddler.

Read this before you arrive. Refer back to it during the trip when something goes sideways, which it will, and which is fine.

10.1 Travelling with a Toddler in Sicily: The Reality

Let's start with the thing nobody tells you clearly enough: **Sicily is one of the best places in Europe to travel with a small child.** Not because of the infrastructure — the infrastructure is uneven at best, as you'll read below — but because of the culture.

Italians love children. Sicilians love children with a particular warmth and expressiveness that can be startling if you come from a northern European tradition where other people's children are left to their parents' management. In Sicily, a toddler in public is a community event. The elderly woman at the market will stop to examine your child and pronounce on their health, beauty, and correct feeding. The waiter will bring something your child didn't order because he thought they might like it. The person at the adjacent café table will make faces and play games with the toddler for twenty minutes without any social awkwardness whatsoever.

This attention is genuine and affectionate. It is not intrusive in the way that can make parents defensive. Accept it with warmth and a smile. Your child will be treated, on this trip, as if they are the most important person in every room they enter. This is good for the child and significantly reduces the social friction of a crying episode in a restaurant.

The practical corollary: Sicilian restaurants and bars are almost always genuinely child-friendly in terms of attitude, even when they are not specifically equipped for children. High chairs may or may not be available; changing facilities are rarely signed but usually possible if you ask; noise and mess are tolerated with a generosity that makes eating out with a toddler less stressful than in many northern European equivalents.

The main challenge is not the attitude but the terrain. The historic centre of Catania is paved in lava stone — uneven, occasionally slippery, genuinely difficult for a pushchair in the narrower streets. The archaeological sites have gravel paths. The clifftop villages have steps. A flexible approach to the pushchair-versus-carrier question will serve you better than insisting on one mode of toddler transport for all situations.

10.2 Stroller & Pushchair Survival

The consolidated guide to navigating Catania and the main day trip sites with a pushchair. The detailed notes per location are in the relevant chapters; this is the summary version you can use for quick reference.

Central Catania — Street by Street

Green (smooth, wide, pushchair-friendly):

- Piazza del Duomo and all four sides of the square
- Via Etnea, the main street (relatively smooth basalt paving, wide pavements)
- The waterfront (Lungomare) south of the cathedral
- Interior of the Cathedral of Sant'Agata
- Castello Ursino courtyard
- Villa Bellini (public park — gravel paths, but wide and level)

Amber (manageable with care — slower pace, some lifting):

- The approach to La Pescheria (steps down from street level; ramp usually available at the side — locate it before descending)
- Inside La Pescheria (narrow, wet ground, navigable but careful)
- Via dei Crociferi (beautiful, lava-cobbled, uneven — worth it, but slow)
- The streets around Piazza Bellini
- Most of the shopping streets running east-west off Via Etnea

Red (carrier recommended — pushchair possible but frustrating):

- The Roman theatre interior (steps, uneven archaeological surface)
- The narrow vicoli (lanes) in the Arab quarter south of the cathedral
- Any street described as a "lane" or "alley" in the text above
- The approaches to Castello Ursino through the surrounding neighbourhood

The rule: if the street looks like a film set for a medieval drama, leave the pushchair where it is and put the toddler in the carrier.

Day Trip Sites

Site	Pushchair verdict	Carrier needed?
Etna (cable car base)	Good — car park and Rifugio area flat	Yes, above cable car
Etna (upper mountain)	Impossible	Essential
Taormina — Greek theatre	Difficult — steps	Yes, for upper tiers
Taormina — Corso Umberto	Manageable	Not required
Taormina — Villa Comunale	Good — wide paths	Not required
Syracuse — Neapolis park	Amber — gravel paths	Useful for cave section
Syracuse — Ortigia	Excellent — smooth stone streets	Not required
Aci Trezza — waterfront	Good	Not required
Aci Castello — castle	Manageable to base; steps up castle	For castle climb

**Stroller-Friendly Route Map**

Green: smooth pavements · Amber: cobblestones · Red: steps only

[openstreetmap.org](https://www.openstreetmap.org) → search "Catania historic centre"

Equipment Recommendations

Pushchair: lightweight and foldable is strongly preferred over a large frame buggy. The Catania lava streets require occasional lifting; the cable cars and jeeps on Etna require folding and stowing; the smaller the frame when folded, the less it becomes a logistics problem.

Carrier/sling: essential. A well-fitting soft structured carrier (Ergobaby, Tula, or similar) is the most important piece of equipment after the pushchair. It handles all the amber and red situations above without stress. For Etna above the cable car station, it is mandatory.

Rain cover: March rain is real. A good pushchair rain cover means a shower doesn't end the day.

Sunshade: March sun can be stronger than you expect, particularly near the coast. A pushchair with a good canopy or an attachable shade is useful from midday onward on clear days.

10.3 Managing the Heat

March is generally kind — daytime temperatures of 16–20°C in Catania, cooler on Etna, occasionally warm in direct sun near the coast. The intense midday heat that makes July and August brutal does not apply to your trip.

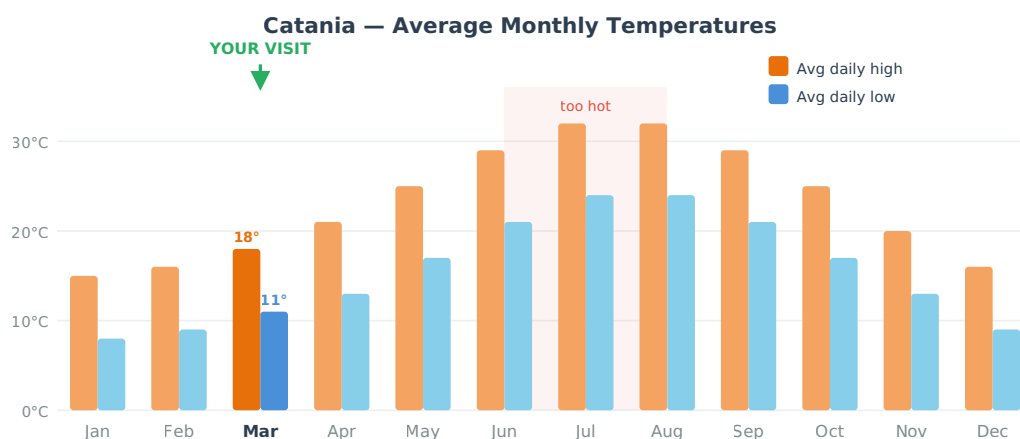
That said:

Sun intensity at lower latitudes is higher than at home even in March. A child who wouldn't burn in an hour in northern Europe in March can burn in 30 minutes in direct Sicilian sunshine. Sunscreen (SPF 50) every morning for any exposed skin. A sun hat is not optional.

The midday stop (noon–3pm) is built into the itinerary for good reason. Even in March, the hours between noon and 3pm are the least pleasant for walking and the most pleasant for sitting in the shade with food and drink. The toddler's nap window coinciding with this period is not a compromise — it is the correct approach.

Water: carry it. The child needs it; you need it. Sicily is warm enough that dehydration creeps up on people who are used to cooler climates. Refill from the street-level water fountains (nasoni) that appear throughout the city, or buy large bottles at the supermarket and carry a smaller one.

For Etna specifically: the temperature at altitude is dramatically colder than in the city, regardless of season. A warm jacket, gloves if you have them, and an extra layer for the toddler are not overcautious — they are necessary. The weather on the mountain is its own system.



10.4 Budget Guide

Sicily is not an expensive destination by western European standards, and Catania is meaningfully cheaper than Palermo, Taormina, or the resort towns of the south coast. Staying in the historic centre means you spend almost nothing on local transport during the city days.

The main budget categories for a week:

Accommodation

You've sorted this already (waterfront district, a good position for the whole trip). Typical nightly rates in Catania for a well-placed apartment or family room: **€80-150/night** depending on quality. A self-catering apartment with kitchen access — as you have — offers better value for a group of five staying a full week.

Food

This is where Sicily rewards you most for not defaulting to tourist-facing restaurants:

Meal type	Typical cost for 2 adults + toddler
Bar breakfast (granita + brioche + coffee)	€6–8
Market street food lunch	€8–15
Tavola calda / quick lunch	€15–25
Trattoria lunch, full meal	€30–50
Good restaurant dinner	€50–80
Gelato per person	€2–3
Arancino per person	€2–3

The strategy for keeping food costs reasonable without compromising quality:

eat your main meal at lunch (same food, same quality, slightly lower prices and faster service) and use evenings for lighter, simpler eating.

Day Trips — Variable Costs

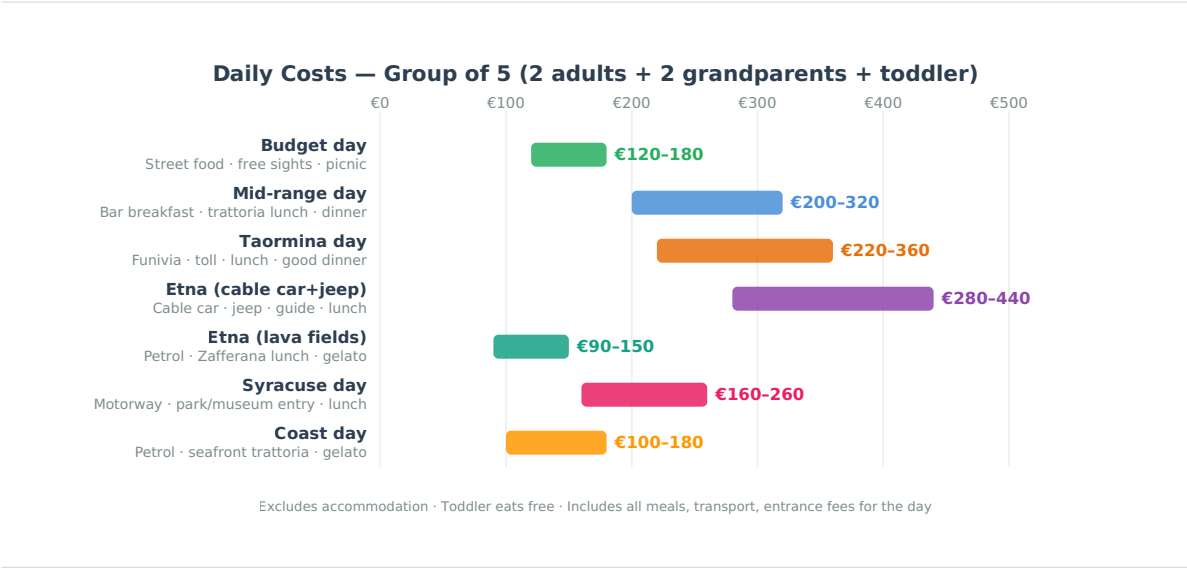
Day trip	Main costs	Approximate total
Etna (cable car + jeep)	Cable car + jeep + lunch	€80–120 for the family
Etna (cable car only)	Cable car + lunch	€50–70
Etna (lower lava fields)	Petrol + lunch	€25–35
Taormina	Motorway toll + parking + funivia + entrance + lunch	€60–90
Syracuse	Motorway toll + park entrance + museum + lunch	€50–70
Coast	Petrol + optional boat trip + lunch	€30–60

Entrance Fees (Catania City)

Most of Catania's baroque exterior is free to experience — the streets, the piazzas, the facades. The things that charge admission:

- Roman theatre: small entrance fee (~€4–6 per adult)
- Castello Ursino museum: free on certain days; check in advance
- Benedictine Monastery: tour fee (~€10 per adult)
- Palazzo Biscari: tour fee (~€8–12 per adult)

Children under various ages are typically free or heavily discounted — ask at each entrance.



10.5 The Timing Cheat Sheet

The single most useful thing in this chapter for day-to-day decisions. When to be where, to get the best of each place without fighting crowds, bad light, or closed doors.

Place / Activity	Best time	Why
La Pescheria market	7–10am	Peak trading, best display, freshest food
Piazza del Duomo	Early morning or golden hour (6pm)	Light on the cathedral, fewer groups
Via Etnea walk	Morning (before 11am) or late afternoon	Shade from buildings; afternoon light on Etna
Etna cable car	Depart Catania by 7:30am	Clouds build from early afternoon; summit clearest in morning
Taormina Greek theatre	9am opening (go first thing)	Tour buses arrive mid-morning; early for best light on Etna backdrop
Syracuse Neapolis park	9am, full morning	Large site; heat and crowds build through the day
Ortigia, Syracuse	Afternoon into evening	Better light on pale stone; market is morning only
Aci Trezza / coast	10am–1pm, then 4–7pm	Midday swim window before afternoon siesta
Benedictine Monastery	Any tour time; check schedule	Indoor — rain-proof; book in advance
La Pescheria (second visit)	Same: 7–10am	It rewards returning; you'll see more the second time
Passeggiata	6–8pm, anywhere on Via Etnea	The daily social ritual; join it on your last evenings
Castello Ursino	Late afternoon	Cooler, quieter, free on certain days
Bar / granita breakfast	7–9am	Locals' timing; best atmosphere and freshest pastries

Best Time of Day — When to Do What						
	6-8am	9-11am	Noon-2pm (nap)	3-5pm	6-8pm Dinner	8-10pm Nap window
La Pescheria market	✓	✓				
Piazza del Duomo		✓		✓		✓
Benedictine Monastery			~	✓		
Castello Ursino			~	✓		
Taormina theatre	✓	✓				
Etna cable car	✓	✓				
Ortigia (Syracuse)		✓	~	✓		
Coast / Faraglioni		✓	~			
Aperitivo + passeggiata					✓	✓
Dinner						✓

10.6 A Short Glossary of Useful Sicilian

Standard Italian will get you everywhere in Catania. But Sicilian — the island's distinct language, which has more in common with ancient Greek, Arab, and Norman French than with standard Italian — is spoken everywhere, particularly between locals and particularly by older generations. A few words and phrases will go a long way; the attempt alone will be received with disproportionate warmth.

Everyday words:

Sicilian	Italian equivalent	When you'll hear it
<i>Beddu / Bedda</i>	Bello / Bella (beautiful)	Said about your toddler, constantly
<i>Picciriddu / Picciridda</i>	Bambino / Bambina (little child)	Also about your toddler
<i>Manciamu!</i>	Mangiamo! (let's eat!)	At any table, before food arrives
<i>Manciarì</i>	Mangiare (to eat)	Everywhere
<i>Fici</i>	Fichi (figs)	At the market
<i>Così duci</i>	Cose dolci (sweet things)	In a pasticceria
<i>Talia!</i>	Guarda! (look!)	What people will say to point things out to your child

Phrases that will make Sicilians delighted you tried:

"Beddu chistu" (BE-ddu KI-stu) — "This is beautiful." Said in a bar about a particularly good granita, in a piazza about the view, anywhere appropriate.

"È 'na Norma!" — The expression meaning "it's excellent/magnificent," derived from the pasta dish and Bellini's opera. Use it after a particularly good meal.

"Cchiu sanu!" (KYO SA-no) — literally "be healthier!" — an exclamation directed at children, meaning something like "grow strong and well." You will hear this said to your toddler. The correct response is a smile and grazie.

On the practical Italian side — the phrases that actually help:

- "Avete un seggiolone?" — Do you have a high chair?
- "Dov'è il bagno?" — Where is the bathroom?
- "Scusi, ha qualcosa per i bambini?" — Excuse me, do you have something for children? (in a restaurant where the menu has nothing obvious)
- "Posso avere il conto, per favore?" — Can I have the bill, please?
- "Com'è fresco il pesce?" — How fresh is the fish? (always ask)
- "Cos'è questo?" — What is this? (pointing at something in a market you don't recognise — the correct way to discover excellent things)

A final note on flexibility and the Sicilian tempo: The plans in this guide are frameworks, not contracts. Sicily operates at a rhythm that does not always synchronise with printed schedules, booking confirmations, or stated opening hours. Restaurants close for a family occasion with no notice. Museums have unexpected staff shortages. The cable car on Etna closes for maintenance on a day you'd planned to go up. Shops shut for the afternoon feast of a local saint you've never heard of. None of this is frustration once you decide it isn't. The Sicilian response to all of the above is: and so? We find something else. The something else, in a place this rich, is never hard to find. Adopt the *arrangiarsi* mindset — the art of improvising — and it becomes one of the things you remember most fondly about the trip. The planned moments are often the good ones. The unplanned ones are frequently the best.

Next: Chapter 11 — Quick Reference

Chapter 11: Quick Reference

This chapter is designed to be the page you photograph on your phone before you go out each day. No prose. Just the information, fast.

11.1 Emergency & Medical

Emergency (all services)	112
Police (Carabinieri)	112
Ambulance	118
Fire	115
Nearest main hospital	Ospedale Garibaldi Centro, Piazza Santa Maria di Gesù — ~15 min walk from the historic centre
EU EHIC card	Covers emergency treatment at public hospitals — carry it always
Pharmacy symbol	Green cross; hours typically 9am–1pm and 4–8pm
<i>*Emergency pharmacy (farmacia di turno)*</i>	Posted in the window of every closed pharmacy
Non-emergency doctor	Ask at your accommodation; most areas have a <i>guardia medica</i> service

11.2 Catania Practicalities

Airport	Catania Fontanarossa (CTA) — 5km south of the historic centre
ZTL zone	Do not drive into the centro storico. Cameras fine you automatically. Ask your accommodation for drop-off routing
Parking	Parcheggio Borsellino (Via Dusmet), Piazza Cavour car park — both near the historic centre
Blue lines (on-street parking)	Paid; buy a ticket from the nearest meter; 1–2 hrs typical limit
Taxi	Taxi stands at the main piazzas; or ask your accommodation to call one
Currency	Euro (€); cards widely accepted; carry some cash for markets and smaller bars
Tipping	Not expected as standard; rounding up or leaving small change is appreciated
Water	Tap water is safe to drink. Street fountains (<i>nasoni</i>) throughout the city
Electricity	Italian standard (Type F, 230V); same as most of Europe
Time zone	CET (UTC+1) in winter; CEST (UTC+2) from late March
Language	Italian; Sicilian dialect common between locals; English spoken at most tourist-facing places

11.3 Driving Reference

Motorway (A18 north / A19 south)	Tolled; pay at exit; keep coins or card accessible
Speed limits	130 km/h motorway; 90 km/h regional roads; 50 km/h in towns
Fuel	Fill up in Catania before day trips — no petrol at altitude on Etna
Driving side	Right (same as continental Europe)
ZTL fines	Can arrive by post weeks later; €80–150 per infraction
Roundabouts	Entering traffic yields in theory; in practice, yield to confidence
Parking (blue lines)	Blue = paid; yellow = residents only; white = usually free

11.4 Day Trip Quick Reference

Destination	Drive from historic centre	Toll	Park at	Notes
Mt Etna (cable car)	~45 min	Yes (A18 S)	Rifugio Sapienza car park	Fill up before leaving; cold at altitude
Taormina	~50 min	Yes (A18 N)	Mazzerò — then funivia up	Do not drive into town
Syracuse / Ortigia	~1 hr	Yes (A18/A19)	Neapolis park entrance; then Ortigia bridge	Full day needed
Aci Trezza / Aci Castello	~20 min	No (SS114)	Waterfront parking, Aci Trezza	Free or cheap parking on street
Acireale	~25 min	No	Central piazza area	Good rainy alternative

11.5 Booking Ahead — What Needs Advance Planning

*Etna cable car / Funivia dell'Etna *		Book online in advance, especially in spring — check funiviaetna.com
Taormina funivia		Walk-up usually fine in March; check funivietormina.it for hours
Benedictine Monastery tour		Book in advance — fills up. Via the University of Catania cultural programme
Palazzo Biscari		Tours on specific days — check in advance and book
INDA Greek theatre festival (Syracuse)		Odd-numbered years, May–June — not applicable to March visit
Accommodation		Done
Car		Done

11.6 Key Phrases

At the bar / pasticceria

Italian	Meaning
<i>Un caffè, per favore</i>	An espresso, please
<i>Una granita di mandorla / pistacchio / caffè</i>	An almond / pistachio / coffee granita
<i>Con brioche?</i>	With a brioche roll? (they'll ask; the answer is yes)
<i>Una cornetta / un cornetto</i>	A croissant-style pastry
<i>Una spremuta di arancia rossa</i>	A freshly squeezed blood orange juice

At the restaurant

Italian	Meaning
<i>Avete un seggiolone?</i>	Do you have a high chair?
<i>Cos'è il pesce del giorno?</i>	What is today's fish?
<i>Com'è fresco?</i>	How fresh is it?
<i>Cosa mi consiglia?</i>	What do you recommend?
<i>Senza glutine</i>	Gluten-free (if relevant)
<i>Il conto, per favore</i>	The bill, please
<i>Possiamo pagare separati?</i>	Can we pay separately?
<i>È buonissimo</i>	It's absolutely delicious

Navigating

Italian	Meaning
<i>Dov'è il bagno?</i>	Where is the bathroom?
<i>Dov'è la farmacia più vicina?</i>	Where is the nearest pharmacy?
<i>Sto cercando la Piazza del Duomo</i>	I'm looking for Piazza del Duomo
<i>Quanto dista a piedi?</i>	How far is it on foot?

Useful Sicilian (see Chapter 10 for more)

Sicilian	Meaning
<i>Beddu / Bedda</i>	Beautiful (said of your child, constantly)
<i>È 'na Norma!</i>	It's magnificent! (food compliment)
<i>Manciarì</i>	To eat

11.7 What to Buy and Bring Home**At the markets (best value; buy direct):**

- Blood oranges (arancia rossa) — by the kilo; extraordinary, cheap
- Local almonds and pistachios — Bronte pistachios from a stall selling them loose
- Capers (capperi) — the Pantelleria capers in salt are the finest; also available jarred
- Dried oregano, fennel seeds, saffron — local, very cheap, very good
- Ricotta salata — the hard salty ricotta used in pasta alla Norma; vacuum-packed
- Local honey — Etna wildflower and chestnut varieties from Zafferana area

At pasticcerie and food shops:

- Pistachio cream (crema di pistacchio) — the Bronte pistachio spread; like Nutella but actually made of something with flavour. Buy more than one jar.
- Almond paste (pasta di mandorle) — Sicilian marzipan, sold in blocks
- Good jarred caponata — one of the better Sicilian foods that travels well
- Torrone (nougat with nuts) — Sicilian version is softer and better than the mainland variety

At ceramics shops (Taormina and Catania):

- Caltagirone style tiles and plates — vivid yellow and blue, extremely packable if wrapped
- A single decorative tile as a practical, flat souvenir
- Avoid the tourist-facing shops on the main drags; the side streets in both Taormina and the Catania centro have better work at lower prices

What not to bother with:

- Limoncello (you can get it at home; it's better in Amalfi anyway)
- Mass-produced "Sicilian" products in attractive packaging sold at airport prices

- Anything described as a "typical Sicilian product" on a label clearly printed in five languages near the tourist information office

11.8 Useful Apps

App	Use
Google Maps	Navigation — download offline maps for Sicily before you travel
Parkopedia	Finding and sometimes paying for parking
Funiviaetna.com	Etna cable car booking and status
Trenitalia	Train times, if you ever want to use the train between cities
DeepL or Google Translate	Menus, signs, market labels
AccuWeather or Meteo.it	Local weather — check the night before for Etna days

— End of Guide —

This guide was written for a family of five — two adults, two grandparents, and a toddler — travelling in Catania and the Sicilian east coast in March 2026. It is a personal document, not a commercial publication. The opinions are honest, the practical tips are specific, and the food advice should be treated as the considered position of someone who has thought about Sicilian arancino for an unreasonable amount of time.

Buon viaggio. Manciarì bonu. 'Na Norma.